A DISSERTATION ON JORDAN PEELE'S US

THE HYPOGEAL COVENANT

Positional Personhood, Simulacral Insurrection, and the Umbilical Ethics of the Tether in Jordan Peele's Us (2019)



JEREMIAH 11:11

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CRITICAL THEORY · FILM PHILOSOPHY · FEMINIST AND BLACK STUDIES

"Therefore thus saith the LORD, Behold, I will bring evil upon them, which they shall not be able to escape; and though they shall cry unto me, I will not hearken unto them."

JEREMIAH 11:11, KING JAMES VERSION

OCTOBER 2026

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Abstract

This dissertation reads Jordan Peele's *Us* (2019) as a work of speculative philosophy whose doppelgänger premise encodes a rigorous and hitherto unformulated theory of the human. Against the two dominant interpretive habits—the psychoanalytic reading of the Tethered as the repressed self, and the sociological reading of the film as a transparent allegory of class—it argues that *Us* elaborates a *hypogeal* ontology: a model of social being in which every upright, visible, enfranchised life is nourished by a buried counterpart whose deprivation is the unacknowledged condition of its flourishing, as the cotyledons of a hypogeally germinating seed remain underground, spending themselves in darkness so that the shoot may rise.

The argument proceeds genealogically. It reconstructs the lineages the film activates—Otto Rank's and Sigmund Freud's theories of the double and the uncanny, Jacques Lacan's mirror stage, C. G. Jung's shadow, René Girard's monstrous double, W. E. B. Du Bois's double consciousness, Frantz Fanon's critique of colonial recognition, the Platonic cave and its Deleuzian reversal, the "old mole" of Shakespeare, Hegel, Marx, and Bataille, and the biblical grammar of covenant and binding compressed into the film's citation of Jeremiah 11:11—and places the film in sustained comparison with the feminist literature of the divided woman (Gilbert and Gubar, Spivak, Clover, Creed, Kristeva, Irigaray, Spillers, Hartman, Butler, Lorde, Carter) and with the humanist tradition from Pico della Mirandola and Kant through Sartre, Césaire, Fanon, Wynter, and Levinas.

Four theses result. First, the film's terminal revelation—that its protagonist is the usurping double—establishes a doctrine of *positional personhood*, in which humanity is conferred by location within a vertical distribution of a single shared

"soul" rather than possessed as an essence. Second, the film exposes the *sororicidal foundation* of liberal feminist selfhood: the self-made woman of the surface is constituted by the strangling of her sister below and must repeat that act to remain herself. Third, the insurrection of the Tethered is bounded by what I term *trickle-down mimesis*: because only forms without content descend from surface to depth, the revolt of the dispossessed can assume only the shape of the dominant culture's own humanitarian spectacle, here Hands Across America. Fourth, the film's closing images—a boy lowering a wolf mask over his face, and a headless human chain stretched across the California hills—gesture, without resolving, toward an ethics beyond both untethering and reversal.

The dissertation formalizes that ethics as *hypogeal humanism*, stated in four axioms (position, nourishment, substitution, acknowledgment), and defends it against Afropessimist, decolonial, posthumanist, and disability-studies objections. Its governing formula is that the human is not the one who stands, but the one who knows on what, and on whom, she stands.

PREFATORY NOTE

On Method, Sources, and Conventions

The question of what "inspired" a film admits two answers that must be kept rigorously apart. The first is *influence*: the documented sources an author consulted, cited, or acknowledged. For *Us* that archive is comparatively narrow, and much of it is declared inside the frame. Peele described the film in its release interviews as concerned with a "collective shadow self," a phrase whose Jungian provenance is unmistakable; he called Michael Jackson the "patron saint of duality"; he sought Steven Spielberg's permission to dress the boy Jason in a *Jaws* (1975) T-shirt; and he has cited *The Twilight Zone*'s "Mirror Image" (1960) as a point of origin for the film's fear of the double. Within the diegesis the film cites Jeremiah 11:11, the USA for Africa benefit Hands Across America (25 May 1986), Jackson's *Thriller*, and, among the videocassettes flanking its opening television, the subterranean B-film *C.H.U.D.* (1984) and *The Goonies* (1985).

The second answer is *genealogy*: the longer history of concepts that a work renders legible, whether or not its author read them. Freud, Du Bois, Fanon, Plato, Deleuze, Bataille, and Spivak belong to this second order. To claim that Peele "drew on" Deleuze would be biographical speculation; to claim that *Us* performs the overturning of Platonism that Deleuze theorized is a claim about the film's form, and it can be tested against the film. This dissertation makes claims of the second kind, and it marks the boundary wherever a claim of the first kind is at stake.

The boundary matters most for race. Peele said at the film's release that *Us*, unlike *Get Out*, is not about race (reported in March 2019). The racial readings in Chapters Two and Three are therefore claims about what the film's form makes legible, not claims about its author's intent.

Its method combines four procedures. The first is symptomatic reading in the tradition of Louis Althusser and Fredric Jameson, which treats a text's formal resolutions as symbolic answers to social contradictions it cannot directly name. The second is close formal analysis of mise-en-scène, sound, editing, costume, and

performance. The third is comparative textual analysis across literature, philosophy, scripture, folklore, and film. The fourth is a philological attentiveness to the film's names, numbers, pronouns, and signage, on the assumption—warranted by Peele's well-publicized density of allusion—that very little in the frame is incidental.

Two conventions govern citation. Dialogue from the film is paraphrased, except for a handful of short lines on whose exact wording an argument turns. Texts in the public domain (scripture in the King James Version, Du Bois, Dunbar, Poe, Shakespeare, Marx, Kant in T. K. Abbott's translation) are quoted directly; modern theoretical works are paraphrased and cited by author and date of first publication. Translations from German, Latin, and Hebrew not otherwise attributed are my own.

A note on names. I refer to the protagonist as "Adelaide" and to her antagonist as "Red" according to the positions they occupy in 2019, specifying where necessary that the woman called Adelaide was born underground and the woman called Red was born above, as Adelaide Thomas, in the family the other woman inherited. That this nomenclature cannot be stabilized without such qualification is the first evidence for the argument that follows.

INTRODUCTION

“It’s Us”—The Grammar of a Pronoun

Humanity is a seat, and seats can be taken.



Us begins not with a character but with a geology. Its opening title card informs the spectator that thousands of miles of tunnels lie beneath the continental United States—abandoned subways, disused service routes, deserted mine shafts—many of them without any known purpose. The sentence is structurally decisive. It locates the film’s horror in infrastructure rather than in the psyche, and it names the scandal the film will spend two hours elaborating: a vast built capacity, sunk beneath the nation, whose function has been forgotten. What has no *known* purpose is not thereby purposeless. It is a purpose that those above have elected not to know.

The second image confirms the first. A television in 1986 plays an advertisement for Hands Across America while the dark glass of the screen returns the reflection of a child. The film thus opens on three superimposed surfaces—earth over tunnel, screen over spectacle, glass over girl—each of which conceals a depth and returns a face. Every subsequent figure in *Us* (the mirror maze, the beach, the lake, the reflecting windows of two holiday houses) is a variation on this triple structure of surface, concealment, and return.

§ The pronoun

The title is a pronoun in the objective case, and the choice is not innocent. English distinguishes the subject who acts (*we*) from the object acted upon (*us*); the humanitarian culture of the mid-1980s, whose emblem plays on that opening television, spoke almost exclusively in the nominative. “We Are the World,” written by Michael Jackson and Lionel Richie for USA for Africa in 1985, and Hands Across America, staged by the same organization a year later, addressed their publics as a collective subject of benevolence: *we* give, *we* join, *we* are the world. *Us* converts that nominative into an accusative. Its “us” is the collective that is acted upon, that is found, that returns.

Two lines of dialogue stage the conversion. When Adelaide demands to know what the intruders are, Red answers: "We're Americans." The dispossessed claim the nominative, the subject-position of the national "we." The line reached theaters in March 2019, after a year in which the federal government, under the administration's "zero tolerance" policy, separated thousands of migrant children from their parents at the southern border, and in which the President called a caravan of Central American migrants an "invasion." Red's answer relocates the invader inside the citizenry. Earlier, when Jason first sees four red-clad figures standing hand in hand at the foot of the driveway, he says: "It's us." The prescriptive grammarian would correct him to *it is we*, since the copula takes the nominative; vernacular English, wiser than its grammar, knows that the self encountered outside itself appears as an object. Between Red's *we* and Jason's *us* lies the film's entire argument. A nation's subject-pronoun is claimed by those it excluded, while its members discover themselves, for the first time, as objects. That the pronoun also spells the abbreviation of the republic—U.S.—was registered by nearly every review on release and is consonant with Peele's description of the film as a study of a collective, national shadow.

§ A vertical cinema

Us is the central panel of what can now be read as a vertical triptych. *Get Out* (2017) introduced the Sunken Place, a psychic abyss into which a Black consciousness falls while a white consciousness pilots the body above. *Us* (2019) geologizes that abyss into a national substrate of tunnels. *Nope* (2022) inverts the axis and locates the predatory spectacle in the sky. Across the three films Peele's cinema thinks in elevations: who is above, who is below, and what passes between them.

The structural rhyme between the first two panels is exact and inverted. In *Get Out* an occupying consciousness takes the surface while the original sinks; in *Us* a body from below takes the surface while the original is buried. The first film concerns the theft of Black embodiment by whiteness. The second, more vertiginously, concerns the theft of a place in the light by anyone, at anyone's expense—with a Black family placed, provocatively, on the side of the beneficiaries of the theft.

§ The argument

Criticism has tended to resolve *Us* into one of two allegories. The psychoanalytic allegory reads the Tethered as the return of the repressed, the shadow-selves of a nation unable to face its own aggression. The sociological allegory reads them as the underclass: the poor, the incarcerated, the unhoused, the precarious. Both readings are correct and both are insufficient, because both preserve the distinction the film exists to destroy—the distinction between an original self, entitled by nature to its place, and a copy, deprived by nature of one. The terminal revelation, that the woman we have followed as Adelaide was born below and seized her place in 1986 by strangling its occupant, abolishes that distinction retroactively. It forces the conclusion that what separates the human from the Tethered is not a property but a position.

From this premise the dissertation develops four theses, each anchored by a coinage.

The first concerns *positional personhood*. The film's metaphysics—a single soul distributed across two bodies—entails that personhood (speech, love, comfort, recognition, the right to a name) is conferred by location within a vertical order rather than inhering in persons. Humanity is a seat, and seats can be taken.

The second concerns the *hypogeal condition*. The term is borrowed from botany, where hypogeal germination names the process by which a seed's cotyledons remain below ground, feeding the shoot that rises into light until they are exhausted. Every life on the surface of *Us* is hypogeally nourished: its warmth is another's cold, its supper another's raw rabbit, its anaesthetized labour another's solitary one. Hypogeal dependence is not exploitation in the classical sense, since the Tethered produce nothing for those above. It is a zero-sum distribution of standing in which flourishing and deprivation are one event viewed from two elevations.

The third concerns the *primal swap* and its feminist consequence. The girl who rises in 1986 becomes, through therapy, ballet, marriage, and motherhood, a model of liberal self-making; the funhouse's imperative—*Find Yourself*—is the motto of her life. Her selfhood rests on an act of sororicide that she must forget and, at the climax, repeat. This is the *sororicidal foundation* of liberal feminist individualism, which Gayatri Chakravorty Spivak first diagnosed in the relation between Jane Eyre and the madwoman whose immolation clears her path.

The fourth concerns *trickle-down mimesis*. What descends from surface to depth is never substance but form: gestures without goods, rituals without nourishment, an advertisement without a meal. The Tethered's revolution therefore takes the shape of the only object that descended intact—the image of Hands Across America, carried below in the memory of the stolen child. The insurrection is a remake.

From these theses the final chapter derives a normative proposal, *hypogeal humanism*. It defines the human neither as the self-fashioning subject of Renaissance humanism, nor as the dignity-bearing rational will of Kant, nor as the abolished figure of

anti- and posthumanism, nor as the structural antagonist of Afropessimism, but as the being that acknowledges its debt to the one on whom it stands—and reorganizes its standing accordingly.

§ Plan of the work

Chapter One reconstructs the genealogy of the double from the shadow-soul of folk belief through Rank, Freud, Jung, Lacan, the nineteenth-century literary doppelgänger, *The Twilight Zone*, Girard, and Robin Wood. Chapter Two inverts Du Bois's double consciousness and tests the film against Fanon, the politics of respectability, Afropessimism, the Black literature of the underground, and the diasporic trickster. Chapter Three reads the film through the feminist genealogy of the divided woman, from the madwoman in the attic to the Final Girl, the abject mother, the captive flesh, and the girl who lies down among wolves. Chapter Four turns to ontology: Plato's cave, Deleuze's simulacrum, Baudrillard's Disneyland, Debord's spectacle, and the theory of trickle-down mimesis. Chapter Five reconstructs the film's political economy through Marx's old mole, Bataille's accursed share, the history of Hands Across America, biopolitics and necropolitics, the settler-colonial ground of the California coast, and Derrida's specters. Chapter Six reads the scriptural and mythic substrate: Jeremiah's covenant, the binding of Isaac, Br'er Rabbit's briar patch, Aristophanes' severed humans, the Fates' shears, Ovid's Io, and the film's onomastics. Chapter Seven passes the humanist, counter-humanist, posthumanist, and feminist-relational traditions through the film and formalizes hypogeal humanism. A coda returns to the final shot.

CHAPTER ONE

Genealogies of the Double: From the Shadow-Soul to the Monstrous Double

1

Suicide is displaced by succession.

The doppelgänger arrives in *Us* freighted with two centuries of theory, and the film's first achievement is to render that inheritance unusable in its received form. In the Romantic and psychoanalytic traditions the double is a figure of interiority: the self's repressed wish, guilt, or mortality, externalized as a twin. In *Us* the double is a figure of exteriority: a person who shares one's soul but not one's world. This chapter traces the lineage in order to locate the precise points at which the film inherits and at which it breaks.

1.1 The shadow as soul: Rank and Chamisso

Otto Rank's *Der Doppelgänger* (1914; expanded 1925) assembled an ethnographic and literary archive in which the shadow, the reflection, the portrait, and the twin function as the soul's earliest figures. In Rank's account, which Freud adopted in 1919, the double begins as an insurance against the destruction of the ego, an energetic denial of death: the soul is the first double, the guarantee that something of me survives my body. Only later, once the primary narcissism that produced it has been surmounted, does the double reverse its sign and become the uncanny harbinger of death. Rank catalogued the taboos that follow—one must not tread on a shadow, wound a reflection, or mutilate a portrait, since injury to the image passes to its owner.

Us literalizes both stages at once. Red's account of the Tethered's origin—their makers could copy bodies but not souls, so that one soul was left shared between two—restores the double to its archaic function as the soul's second body. And the Tethered arrive, as Rank's late double does, as messengers of death. The folk taboo becomes a social contract with one decisive amendment: what is done to the surface body is borne below, but the wounds of the buried body never pass upward.

Adelbert von Chamisso's *Peter Schlemihls wundersame Geschichte* (1814), which Rank read closely, supplies the economic version of the figure. Schlemihl sells his shadow to a man in grey for Fortunatus's purse, which never empties; he becomes rich and is shunned, for a shadowless man scandalizes every observer. The surface Americans of *Us* are Schlemihls of a later dispensation. Their purses do not empty because their shadows were sold, but the sale was concluded on their behalf by the anonymous makers to whom Red alludes, and the scandal Schlemihl could not conceal has been solved by burial. Chamisso's society stigmatized shadowlessness because it could see it; Peele's society has made shadowlessness invisible by placing the shadows underground.

1.2 Freud: the uncanny, the reel, the shadow of the object

Freud's "Das Unheimliche" (1919) begins in philology. Pursuing *heimlich* through its dictionary senses, Freud found that the word for the homely and familiar shades, by its own development, into the word for the concealed and secret, until it coincides with its antonym. The uncanny is therefore not the strange but the familiar returned in estranged form. Freud found the formula in Schelling's *Philosophie der Mythologie*: "Unheimlich nennt man Alles, was im Geheimnis, im Verborgenen, in der Latenz bleiben sollte und hervorgetreten ist"—uncanny is the name for everything that ought to have remained in secrecy, in concealment, in latency, and has come forth.

Peele's home invasion is Schelling's sentence staged. The intruders who appear at 11:11 are not strangers at the door of the *Heim*; they are the *Heim* itself, the family returned to the family. Freud's catalogue of uncanny motifs is distributed across the film with taxonomic thoroughness: the double; involuntary repetition (the recurring 11:11; the red frisbee that settles exactly over a circle printed on a beach towel, an eclipse in miniature); the omnipotence of thoughts (Adelaide's conviction that something is coming for her); and the castration complex, which Freud derived from Hoffmann's *Sandman* and its threat to the eyes. The Tethered's weapon belongs to this last register. Scissors are the punitive instrument of the bourgeois nursery: in Heinrich Hoffmann's *Struwwelpeter* (1845), the tailor with great shears cuts off the thumbs of the boy who sucks them. The Tethered carry the nursery's castrating tool, gilded.

Freud also recorded his own encounter with the double. Alone in a sleeping compartment, he saw an elderly gentleman in a dressing gown enter, rose to set him right, and realized that the intruder was his own reflection in the mirror of the connecting door; he remembered having thoroughly disliked the man's appearance. The elementary form of the uncanny double is a failure of self-recognition tinged with aversion. The funhouse of 1986 elevates the anecdote into a founding scene: a girl meets her reflection, does not know it, and is undone by it.

Jenseits des Lustprinzips (1920) supplies the figure that gives the Tethered their name. Freud observed his grandson throwing a wooden reel tied to a string over the edge of his curtained cot with a drawn-out o-o-o-o (*fort*, "gone"), then pulling it back

with a joyful *da* ("there"). The game masters the mother's absence by staging disappearance and return with an object that never fully leaves, because it is tethered. The Tethered are the nation's reel. The culture casts its poor beneath sight (*fort*) and celebrates their spectacular return in humanitarian ritual (*da*) at times of its own choosing; Hands Across America is a *da*. *Us* shows the reel returning on its own schedule, the string pulled from the other end. Freud's essay moves from the reel to the repetition compulsion and from repetition to the death drive; the film travels the same road in reverse, from a death drive enacted with scissors back to the game of the reel.

"Trauer und Melancholie" (1917) supplies the clinical portrait of the protagonist. In mourning, the libido withdraws from a lost object; in melancholia, the object is not relinquished but incorporated into the ego by identification: "Der Schatten des Objekts fiel so auf das Ich"—the shadow of the object fell upon the ego. Adelaide's affect—vigilant, guarded, anhedonic at the beach, tightening at every coincidence—is melancholic in the strict sense. Freud observed that the melancholic may know whom he has lost but not what he has lost in him. Adelaide inverts the formula. She knows *what* she lost, a night in a mirror maze, but not *whom*, because the lost object is the girl she became. She does not suffer the shadow of the object; she is that shadow, fallen upon an ego she took.

1.3 Jung: shadow, persona, synchronicity

Peele's own vocabulary—a "collective shadow self"—is Jungian, and the film rewards a Jungian reading up to a precise limit. For Jung the shadow comprises the inferior and disowned contents of the personality, personal and collective; the persona is the mask that mediates between the ego and social expectation; individuation requires the conscious integration of the shadow, without which it is projected outward as an enemy (*Aion*, 1951). The film is saturated with personae in the literal sense: Jason's werewolf mask, Pluto's mask over burned skin, the composed face Adelaide wears among the Tylers. Its hall of mirrors is a hall of persona production.

Jung's late concept of synchronicity (with Wolfgang Pauli, 1952)—an acausal connecting principle disclosed in meaningful coincidence—describes the phenomenology of the tether exactly. Adelaide's dread is triggered by coincidences she cannot explain causally: the frisbee, the clock, the man with the sign. The tether is a synchronicity machine, binding events without mechanism.

The limit arrives with the twist. A Jungian therapy of the nation would demand that the persona integrate its shadow. But *Us* reveals that the persona *is* the shadow: the woman who has individuated into a successful wife and mother is the shadow that rose. Integration would require the ego's self-abolition; individuation becomes indistinguishable from confession. Adelaide chooses the persona, and the film's final smile is the smile of a persona that knows.

1.4 Lacan: the funhouse as mirror stage

Lacan's "Le stade du miroir" (1936; revised 1949) describes the infant's jubilant assumption of its specular image as the matrix of the ego: the I forms in an exteriority, as an image anticipating a mastery the body lacks, and is founded on *méconnaissance*, a constitutive misrecognition. The funhouse sign—*Find Yourself*—is the mirror stage's imperative printed over a door. The girl finds herself and is found by herself. Rimbaud's formula, *Je est un autre*, is literalized: the one who walks out of the maze is the image.

Lacan's companion paper "L'agressivité en psychanalyse" (1948) explains why the encounter turns lethal. The imaginary relation to the semblable is structurally rivalrous; in infantile transitivism the child who strikes reports that it was struck, and the dyad oscillates between identification and the murderous logic of *me or you*. Only the symbolic order—language, law, the mediating third—pacifies the dyad. At the decisive moment of 1986 the father is absent from his function. He is playing Whac-A-Mole, and the paternal law that should interpose itself between the girl and her image is absorbed in a carnival game. Left to the imaginary, the dyad resolves itself by strangulation.

The aftermath distributes the two girls across Lacan's registers. The child who rises is shepherded into the symbolic by a psychologist who prescribes drawing and dance; she acquires speech late and well. The child who descends is expelled from the symbolic altogether: her larynx is crushed, and her voice survives as a rasp that is less speech than the residue of the real in speech. The Tethered as a population are pre-symbolic—an imaginary without law, moving in mirrored synchrony, communicating in grunts and cries. Red's narration by the hearth is the first symbolic act ever performed from below.

1.5 The literary doppelgänger: Poe, Andersen, Dostoevsky, Stevenson, Wells

Edgar Allan Poe's "William Wilson" (1839) furnishes the film's most uncanny literary precedent. The narrator's namesake, who shares his birthday and copies his dress and gait, can never raise his voice above a whisper because of a weakness, as Poe has it, in the "faucial or guttural organs." The double's ruined voice is Red's. The tale ends with the narrator's murder of his double and the double's last pronouncement: "In me didst thou exist—and, in my death, see by this image, which is thine own, how utterly thou hast murdered thyself." Whether the family's surname is homage or accident, the film inherits Poe's grammar—the double as conscience, the killing of the double as suicide—and revises its conclusion. Adelaide kills her double and survives. Suicide is displaced by succession: the self that kills its double does not die; it inherits.

Hans Christian Andersen's "Skyggen" ("The Shadow," 1847) is the tale whose plot *Us* most closely reproduces. A scholar's shadow detaches, prospers, and returns years later wealthy and seemingly corporeal; it takes the impoverished scholar into service as its

own shadow, courts a princess, and—when the scholar threatens to reveal the truth—persuades her that its shadow has gone mad and believes itself a man. The scholar is executed on the eve of the wedding. Andersen anticipates not only the twist but its juridical asymmetry: whoever holds the position of the original holds the power to define the other as a deranged copy. The final duel of *Us* is fought on precisely these terms.

Fyodor Dostoevsky's *Dvoinik* (*The Double*, 1846) supplies the social mechanism. Golyadkin Junior, suave and ingratiating, outperforms the clerk Golyadkin Senior in office and society and displaces him; the original ends in an asylum. The double succeeds because it is the better performer of social competence, as Adelaide becomes a more accomplished performer of bourgeois womanhood than the original was ever permitted to become. Robert Louis Stevenson's *Strange Case of Dr Jekyll and Mr Hyde* (1886) gives the double its class coordinates: Utterson, groping for a word for Hyde, settles on "troglodytic"—cave-dwelling—and late-Victorian readers recognized in Hyde the degenerate residuum of the slum. H. G. Wells's *The Time Machine* (1895) completes the movement by projecting class divergence into speciation: the Morlocks, descendants of an industrial proletariat relegated underground, feed on the Eloi of the upper world. *Us* inherits Wells's vertical cosmology and inverts its diet. The Tethered eat rabbits, not people, until the night they rise.

1.6 "Mirror Image": from cosmology to infrastructure

Rod Serling's "Mirror Image" (*The Twilight Zone*, 1960) places Millicent Barnes in a rain-soaked bus terminal where she glimpses a double who has taken her luggage and her seat. She hypothesizes a parallel world whose inhabitants cross over and must displace their originals in order to live; no one believes her, and she is led away as mad, while a skeptical young man glimpses his own double running into the rain. The episode bequeaths to *Us* three elements: the double who replaces, the storm (the 1986 sequence unfolds as one breaks over the boardwalk), and the classification of the original as insane. What Peele changes is the location of the double's world. Serling's doubles arrive from a parallel plane; Peele's arrive from beneath the parking lot. The metaphysical *elsewhere* becomes the political *below*, and cosmology becomes infrastructure.

1.7 Girard: mimesis, the monstrous double, the failed sacrifice

René Girard's theory of mimetic desire (*Mensonge romantique et vérité romanesque*, 1961) holds that desire is triangular: we desire objects because a model desires them. The comedy of the Wilson–Tyler friendship is a comedy of mimetic rivalry. Gabe buys a temperamental second-hand boat, *Craw Daddy*, in transparent emulation of Josh Tyler's ease; Josh deflects with casual superiority; Kitty appraises Adelaide over a drink with the glazed interest of a rival who need not compete.

La violence et le sacré (1972) explains where such comedy leads. Mimetic rivalry, intensifying, erodes the differences on which order rests and produces a sacrificial crisis in which antagonists become indistinguishable—"monstrous doubles" of one another—until the community converges upon a single victim whose expulsion restores difference. The Untethering is the sacrificial crisis made literal. The difference between surface and depth collapses; the antagonists are doubles in the strictest sense; the violence spreads mimetically, household to household. Adelaide's killing of Red appears to be the founding sacrifice that restores the order of above and below.

Girard's mature work (*Des choses cachées depuis la fondation du monde*, 1978), however, argues that the sacrificial mechanism functions only so long as the community misrecognizes the victim's innocence; once that innocence is revealed—as, for Girard, the Gospels reveal it—sacrifice can no longer produce peace. *Us* reveals the victim's innocence at the very moment of sacrifice. As Adelaide drives away, memory returns, and the spectator learns that the slain monster was the original. The mechanism fails before our eyes. The final aerial image, a human chain running to the horizon, is the image of a crisis that sacrifice can no longer close.

1.8 From the repressed to the oppressed: Robin Wood

Robin Wood's "An Introduction to the American Horror Film" (1979) offered a formula: normality is threatened by the Monster. Drawing on Herbert Marcuse's distinction between basic and surplus repression (*Eros and Civilization*, 1955), Wood read the monster as the return of what bourgeois patriarchal society represses within and oppresses without, and he enumerated its Others: women, the proletariat, other cultures, ethnic minorities, alternative ideologies, nonconforming sexualities, and children. The Tethered compress the whole inventory into a single figure.

Yet *Us* adds what Wood's formula lacked. The Other is no longer merely projected onto others; it shares one's soul. The double ceases to be a psychological figure—my interior made visible—and becomes a political one: my exterior, my creditor, the one whose share I consume. The repressed and the oppressed, which Wood held in analogy, are fused into a single body. That fusion is the passage the remainder of this dissertation follows.

CHAPTER TWO

Du Bois Inverted: One Soul, Two Bodies

2

Humanity is a seat in a vertical theatre, and the Black family's seat is in the front row of a theatre it does not own.

The most consequential conceptual inheritance of *Us* is not psychoanalytic but Du Boisian, and it arrives inverted. This chapter argues that the film's metaphysics of the tether is a negative image of double consciousness, and that the inversion carries the film's racial thought beyond both the protest tradition and its Afropessimist critique, toward the doctrine of positional personhood.

2.1 Two souls in one body; one soul in two bodies

The locus classicus appears in the first chapter of *The Souls of Black Folk* (1903): "It is a peculiar sensation, this double-consciousness, this sense of always looking at one's self through the eyes of others, of measuring one's soul by the tape of a world that looks on in amused contempt and pity. One ever feels his two-ness,—an American, a Negro; two souls, two thoughts, two unreconciled strivings; two warring ideals in one dark body, whose dogged strength alone keeps it from being torn asunder."

Du Bois's figure is intrapsychic: two souls quarrel within a single body, held together by endurance. The metaphysics Red expounds underground inverts every term. Where Du Bois places two souls in one body, Peele places one soul in two bodies. The inversion has four consequences.

First, double consciousness is externalized into double existence. The division Du Bois located within the Black subject is redistributed across a social line, so that the two-ness is no longer felt but inhabited: one lives on each side of it. Second, the "dogged strength" that alone prevents the body from being "torn asunder" becomes the tether itself, and the Untethering is precisely the tearing asunder that Du Bois's subject heroically resists. The golden scissors are the instrument of a sundering Du Bois could imagine only as catastrophe. Third, Du Bois's pairing—"an American, a Negro"—returns in Red's answer to Adelaide. "We're Americans" does not reconcile the two terms; it

seizes the first on behalf of those consigned to the structural place of the second. Fourth, double consciousness is a matter of sight, of looking at oneself through others' eyes. In *Us* the Tethered see the surface (they mirror it) but are unseen by it; the surface neither sees nor is seen. Only one character has looked from both sides. Adelaide is the film's sole bearer of something like double consciousness, and it manifests as dread.

Du Bois opened the book with the question the white world never asks aloud but always implies: "How does it feel to be a problem?" The Tethered are a problem that has never been put as a question. Red's monologue is the answer to a question no one above has asked.

2.2 The Veil and the glass

Du Bois's governing image is the Veil, the membrane through which Black Americans perceive the white world—"gifted with second-sight in this American world"—while remaining unseen within it. The funhouse mirror is a Veil with its polarity reversed: it shows the self to itself while concealing the depth behind the glass. The film's most daring move is to place its Black family on the side of the Veil that does not see. The Wilsons are not the subjects of second sight but its beneficiaries, and the Veil they fail to perceive is no longer the color line alone but the line between surface and depth. Race does not vanish from the film; it is cross-wired with standing, so that a family marked by the color line in one direction is unmarked by the tether line in another.

2.3 Dunbar's mask

Paul Laurence Dunbar's "We Wear the Mask" (1895) supplies a second Black lyric genealogy: "We wear the mask that grins and lies, / It hides our cheeks and shades our eyes." Dunbar's *we* is a collective of concealment, a people whose survival depends upon a face that misreports its interior. *Us* multiplies masks along Dunbar's line: Jason's werewolf mask, Pluto's mask over burned skin, and Adelaide's composure, the most perfect mask in the film because no one, including its wearer, knows it to be one. Dunbar's *we* wears the mask before "the world"; Peele's *us* is what appears when the mask is lifted and the face beneath proves to be the same face. In the final shot Jason lowers his mask, and the film's last gesture can be read as Dunbar's: the election of the mask.

2.4 From the epidermal to the sartorial schema

In *Peau noire, masques blancs* (1952), Fanon recounts the scene on a train in which a white child's frightened exclamation, "Tiens, un nègre!" ("Look, a Negro!"), fixes him in place by naming him with a racial noun before he has spoken: his bodily schema collapses, displaced by what he calls a racial epidermal schema, the body read as skin. Jason's "It's us" is that scene's inversion. A Black child, looking at strangers, does not fix them with a racial noun; he names them with the first-person plural, and so recognizes himself in them. The recognition terrifies not because the others are other but because they are not.

The film secures the inversion through a formal decision whose consequences have been underexamined. The doubles share their originals' phenotype exactly; Lupita Nyong'o plays Adelaide and Red, Winston Duke plays Gabe and Abraham. Horror and Hollywood have long coded virtue as light and menace as dark, and colorism has routinely assigned darker-skinned performers to the monstrous pole of a binary. *Us* forecloses that mapping: the bourgeois mother and the subterranean revolutionary share one face and one complexion. Difference is relocated from the skin to the garment.

I call this relocation the *sartorial schema*. The Tethered are read not through epidermis but through uniform: a red coverall that evokes at once the prison jumpsuit, the industrial boiler suit, and the red leather jacket of Jackson's "Thriller"; a single glove, Jackson's emblem; golden scissors. The sartorial schema reads the body through institution rather than race—through the carceral and industrial apparatus that, in the 1980s, was producing a vast uniformed population out of sight. In Fanon the skin is a uniform one cannot remove. In *Us* the uniform is a skin one has been issued.

2.5 Fanon: two towns, replacement, and the pitfalls

Les damnés de la terre (1961) opens by describing the colonial world as a world cut in two, Manichaean in structure: the settlers' town, lit and paved and well fed, and the natives' town, crowded, hungry, and dark. Decolonization, Fanon insists, is in its first moment simply the replacement of one "species" of men by another, and the look the colonized turns upon the settlers' town is a look of envy that dreams of possession—of sitting at the settler's table and sleeping in his bed. Red's program is this replacement in its purest form. The Tethered propose not to abolish the line between the two towns but to cross it and kill those who stand on the other side.

Fanon's account of violence belongs in this reading without softening. Colonialism, he argued in the book's first chapter, is violence in its natural state, installed and maintained by the settler's police and soldiers; the violence of the colonized answers a violence that came first, and Fanon held that it could restore to them a self-respect the colonial order had taken. *Us* stages that sequence and complicates it. The first violence

belongs to the makers, who bound a population beneath the country and abandoned it. The girl who escaped in 1986 answered it, but her counter-violence fell on another child: she choked the surface girl unconscious, handcuffed her to a bed below, and took her place. Red's scissors answer that second violence. The film does not refute Fanon's sequence; it shows what becomes of it when the makers are out of reach and counter-violence falls on the nearest double. Fanon's book ends, too, with case histories of the psychic wounds such violence leaves on colonized and colonizer alike, and the film keeps that ledger in Adelaide's dread.

Fanon's book contains its own warning, and Us dramatizes it with uncanny precision. "The Pitfalls of National Consciousness" describes the national bourgeoisie that inherits the colonizer's position without a productive vocation of its own: it occupies the abandoned villas, adopts the departing elite's manners, and becomes the intermediary of the order it replaced. Adelaide is the national bourgeoisie of the Tethered. She crossed in 1986, took the settler's bed, built a family, and never returned for the others. When they come for their share, she kills their leader. Her success is the pitfall incarnate: liberation as substitution reproduces the structure it escaped, and the escaped captive becomes the warden. Positional personhood here acquires its political definition. Where humanity is a seat, whoever takes a seat inherits its obligations to the order that built it.

2.6 Respectability and the Moynihan shadow

The Wilsons bear the signifiers of the Black professional class: Gabe's Howard University sweatshirt, the inherited Santa Cruz house, the second-hand boat bought to keep pace with the Tylers, the gentle, self-mocking comedy of Gabe's protective masculinity. Evelyn Brooks Higginbotham's *Righteous Discontent* (1993) named the strategy that underwrites such self-presentation the "politics of respectability": the cultivation of bourgeois decorum as a claim on citizenship and a shield against stigma.

The stigma has a canonical text. Daniel Patrick Moynihan's *The Negro Family: The Case for National Action* (1965) diagnosed a "tangle of pathology" rooted in a matriarchal family structure, a thesis Hortense Spillers would dismantle two decades later. The Tethered Wilsons are the report's projection given flesh: a commanding matriarch who alone speaks; a father reduced to grunts and force; a son disfigured and masked; a daughter feral and grinning. Peele stages the respectable Black family against the very image respectability exists to refute.

The twist detonates the arrangement. The respectable mother is the projection's daughter, the shadow wearing the costume of the norm. Respectability is revealed not as the opposite of the pathologizing image but as its successful disguise, and the bargain it offers—propriety in exchange for protection—as a mask laid over a substitution. The film does not endorse the projection. It exposes respectability as a

fiction of essence in a world of positions: decorum protects nothing, because what it protects was never a nature but a seat.

2.7 Red, White & Black: Afropessimism and positional personhood

Frank B. Wilderson III's *Red, White & Black: Cinema and the Structure of U.S. Antagonisms* (2010) organizes American cinema around three structural positions: the "Red" position of the "Savage," Wilderson's deliberately colonial name for the Native as settler ontology constitutes it, whose grammar of suffering is genocide and the loss of land and sovereignty; the "White" position of the Settler-Master, coextensive with the Human; and the "Black" position of the Slave, whose suffering is not a conflict within civil society but an antagonism with it. The chromatic triad of *Us*—red jumpsuits, white Tylers, Black Wilsons—maps onto these positions too exactly to be dismissed and too scrambled to be applied.

Orlando Patterson's *Slavery and Social Death* (1982) defined slavery through three conditions: permanent violent domination, natal alienation, and general dishonor. The Tethered satisfy each. They are natally alienated, possessing no genealogy except mimicry and no kinship except assignment; Red recounts being given Abraham without regard to love, a union the tether compelled and in which her body bore the sexual and reproductive life the surface woman chose. They are dishonored, eating raw rabbit in white-tiled corridors and speaking in grunts. They are dominated, their every movement dictated by bodies they have never seen. Calvin Warren's *Ontological Terror* (2018) argues that within an antiblack metaphysics the free Black is an impossible figure, a terror to an order that requires blackness to function as nothing. The escaped Tethered is ontological terror in Warren's sense: a terror to the surface, were she discovered, and to herself, as her dread at the beach attests.

The film thus formalizes the Afropessimist claim that the Human requires a non-human double for its coherence. Yet it refuses Afropessimism's racial assignment of positions: every American, of every race, has a double below. Two readings follow. The Afropessimist objection holds that *Us* universalizes social death and so dissolves the specificity of antiblackness into a generic class allegory—a liberal recuperation. The Marxist reply holds that the film reveals positions as transposable and therefore historical. The present argument occupies neither pole. *Us* places a Black family on the surface precisely to show that Black occupancy of the human position is borrowed and precarious. The Wilsons are tethered twice: vertically, to doubles who share their souls; horizontally, to the Tylers, whose ease defines the standard of their aspiration. Positional personhood names this double tethering. Humanity is a seat in a vertical theatre, and the Black family's seat is in the front row of a theatre it does not own.

2.8 The Black literature of the underground

Us belongs to a distinguished lineage of Black subterranean speech. The narrator of Ralph Ellison's *Invisible Man* (1952) inhabits a forgotten basement wired with 1,369 bulbs fed by current stolen from Monopolated Light & Power; he is invisible because others refuse to see him, and he closes by wondering whether, on the lower frequencies, he speaks for the reader. Red speaks on the lowest frequency available to a human throat, and she does claim to speak for "us." Richard Wright's *The Man Who Lived Underground*, drafted in 1941–42 and published complete only in 2021, sends Fred Daniels, falsely accused, into the sewers, from which he watches the surface world as an absurd theatre; when he climbs out to testify to what he has seen, the police shoot him. The testimony of the underground cannot be received at the surface. Red's emergence ends as Daniels's does.

Zora Neale Hurston enters the film through the daughter's name. In *Their Eyes Were Watching God* (1937), the child Janie learns that she is Black by failing to recognize herself in a photograph among white playmates—a racialized mirror stage, contemporaneous with Lacan's first, unpublished presentation of his own in 1936—and later discovers that she has an inside and an outside, and learns to keep them apart. Hurston's essay "How It Feels to Be Colored Me" (1928) supplies the beach sequence its caption: "I feel most colored when I am thrown against a sharp white background." Adelaide on the sand beside Kitty Tyler, studying an ease she has learned to imitate, is Hurston's sentence composed as a shot.

2.9 Trickster ontology: the spider, the rabbit, and the two-colored cap

Two folk animals preside over the film. In the hall of mirrors the girl whistles "The Itsy Bitsy Spider," the nursery song of a spider washed down a spout that climbs again; Red whistles it once more shortly before she dies. The spider recalls Anansi, the Akan trickster who purchased all stories from the sky god Nyame and crossed the Middle Passage into the folklore of the Caribbean and the American South. The underground teems with rabbits, which recall Br'er Rabbit, trickster of the African American tales that Joel Chandler Harris collected and appropriated in 1880, whose most celebrated ruse is to beg his captor not to throw him into the briar patch—where, once thrown, he crows that he was bred and born. Harris's publication of Black oral tradition under a white byline is itself a surface's appropriation of a depth.

The trickster's ethic is survival by inversion: the weak defeat the strong through disguise, mimicry, and the manipulation of the strong's expectations. The underground-born Adelaide is the film's trickster heroine—Anansi climbing the spout, Br'er Rabbit escaping into the place he was supposed to fear—and the trickster's moral ambiguity is hers. Henry Louis Gates Jr.'s *The Signifying Monkey* (1988) theorized the African American practice of Signifyin(g) as repetition with a signal difference. The

Tethered's mimicry is Signifyin(g) degraded into repetition without difference. The film's sonic emblem restores the difference: Michael Abels's "Tethered Mix" of the Luniz's "I Got 5 On It" (1995) slows a 1995 Oakland party record about two friends each putting in five dollars toward a ten-dollar bag of marijuana into a dirge. The purchase is not incidental: it is the act that the era's drug enforcement, which fell disproportionately on young Black men, turned into arrest records and prison terms, the population the red coverall recalls. The vernacular economics of halves rhymes with the metaphysics of the halved soul.

Gates's tutelary figure, the Yoruba Èṣù-Elegbara, guardian of crossroads and of interpretation, is the hero of a tale in which he walks between two friends wearing a cap dyed a different color on each side; each swears to the color he saw, and they come to blows. The tale is a parable of positional epistemology: what one sees is a function of where one stands. *Us* extends the parable from perception to being. Where one stands determines not only what one sees but what one is.

CHAPTER THREE

The Madwoman in the Tunnel: Feminist Genealogies of the Divided Woman

3

The positions persist; only their occupants rotate.

At the center of *Us* stand two women played by one actor, and the film's decisive acts—the strangling of 1986, the monologue by the hearth, the duel beneath the boardwalk—are performed by women upon women. The men are comic (Gabe), mute (Abraham), distracted (the father at his game), or abstract (the anonymous makers). This chapter reads the film through the feminist genealogy of the divided woman and argues that it stages, with exceptional rigor, the tragedy of a feminism of position: two daughters of a patriarchal order locked in a struggle over the single place that order allots.

3.1 From the attic to the tunnel

Sandra M. Gilbert and Susan Gubar's *The Madwoman in the Attic* (1979) argued that nineteenth-century women writers projected their rage into dark doubles who act out what their heroines must suppress. The paradigm is Bertha Mason, confined in the attic of Thornfield, whom they read as the darkest and most truthful double of Jane Eyre: each eruption of Bertha's violence answers a moment of Jane's suppressed anger. *Us* relocates the madwoman from the attic to the tunnel—from domestic verticality, the upstairs room in which a husband conceals an inconvenient wife, to national verticality, the substrate in which a society conceals inconvenient lives. Red is Bertha: rage made flesh, voice made noise, emerging to set the house alight.

The twist subjects the model to an inversion Gilbert and Gubar did not imagine. Their Jane survives, marries, and inherits; her madwoman burns. Peele's Jane—the composed, watchful, domestically successful Adelaide—is herself the escaped madwoman. The Angel in the House, Coventry Patmore's emblem of self-effacing femininity (1854–62), whom Virginia Woolf held that every woman writer must kill in order to write ("Professions for Women," 1931), is in *Us* the madwoman's success story.

And she kills: not, as in Woolf, the Angel within, in an emancipatory act, but the madwoman without, in a conservative one. The Angel who was once the madwoman strangles the woman who now occupies the attic. The positions persist; only their occupants rotate.

3.2 The sororicidal foundation: Spivak

Gayatri Chakravorty Spivak's "Three Women's Texts and a Critique of Imperialism" (1985) turned Gilbert and Gubar's reading against itself. *Jane Eyre*, Spivak argued, stages the emergence of the "feminist individualist" heroine through the sacrifice of the Creole woman from the colonies: Bertha must burn the house and leap from its battlements so that Jane may marry and narrate. The self-immolation of the colonial subject is the precondition of the metropolitan woman's selfhood. Jean Rhys's *Wide Sargasso Sea* (1966), which Spivak read alongside it, restores Bertha's history as Antoinette Cosway and marks the violence of the name: Rochester renames her, and the renaming is the first dispossession.

Us is the most exact cinematic allegory of Spivak's argument yet produced. Adelaide's liberal selfhood—recovery from trauma, a disciplined body, marriage and motherhood, a life lived under the funhouse slogan *Find Yourself*—rests on the strangling of a sister below, who loses her voice, her name (she becomes "Red," a color rather than a person), her family, and the sun. That is the primal swap. The climax demands its repetition: to remain herself, Adelaide must kill her sister again.

I call this structure the *sororicidal foundation* of liberal feminist selfhood. It names the condition in which one woman's emancipation upward is purchased by another woman's burial, and in which the emancipated woman's continued standing requires the periodic re-burial of her double. The film offers no moral comfort. Its emancipated woman is not a villain; she is a survivor who has done, twice, what the structure required.

3.3 Can the subaltern speak? Red's voice and the two senses of representation

Spivak's "Can the Subaltern Speak?" (1988) argued that the subaltern's speech act fails not because she is silent but because no institutional circuit exists in which her utterance can be heard as speech. Red's voice is that thesis rendered as sound. Her larynx crushed in childhood, she speaks in a strangled rasp that the spectator first hears as monstrous and that the film's first half encodes as the voice of a villain. Only the twist re-sounds it as the voice of a wound. Even then her speech is routed through borrowed forms: she tells her history as a fairy tale, beginning "Once upon a time," adopting the oldest genre available to the dispossessed.

Spivak's essay turned on a sentence from Marx's *Eighteenth Brumaire* concerning the French smallholding peasantry: "Sie können sich nicht vertreten, sie müssen vertreten werden"—they cannot represent themselves; they must be represented. Spivak distinguished two senses that English collapses into "represent": *Vertretung*, speaking for, as a proxy or deputy; and *Darstellung*, re-presentation, as in a portrait or a staging. Red performs both. She speaks for the Tethered, who have no words; and she stages them, through the human chain she designed, as a portrait of themselves for the helicopters. The chain is a *Darstellung* without *Vertretung*: an image that demands to be seen but carries no terms that could be negotiated. In Peele's version the subaltern cannot speak, but she can compose a picture.

3.4 The Final Girl as impostor

Carol J. Clover's *Men, Women, and Chain Saws* (1992) identified the slasher's Final Girl: watchful, resourceful, sexually reticent, the one who looks, survives, and turns the killer's weapon against him. Clover argued that she functions as a congenial double for the adolescent male spectator, a site of cross-gender identification. Adelaide possesses every attribute—the hypervigilance that reads danger before others see it, the resourcefulness under siege, the climactic duel. The twist turns Clover's genre-theoretical double into a literal one and reveals the Final Girl's watchfulness as the impostor's vigilance. She watches because she knows what she is watching for.

Linda Williams's "When the Woman Looks" (1984) observed that in classical horror the heroine's look at the monster often discloses an affinity: both are freakish within the patriarchal economy of the gaze. *Us* converts affinity into identity; when Adelaide looks at Red she sees not a kindred freak but herself. Laura Mulvey's "Visual Pleasure and Narrative Cinema" (1975) assigned woman the position of image and man the position of bearer of the look. In *Us* both bearers of the decisive look are women, and the man is spectacle—Gabe's comic body, Abraham's mute one.

bell hooks's "The Oppositional Gaze" (1992) theorized the critical, resistant looking of Black women spectators who look back at a cinema that refused them. The film supplies its own oppositional gaze within the diegesis: Zora's appalled stare at her mother in the Tylers' house, where Adelaide's violence exceeds defense and approaches relish. The daughter's look, turned not against the screen but against the mother, is the first crack in the mask. Jason's look in the final scene is the second.

3.5 The monstrous-feminine, the abject, and the cave as womb

Barbara Creed's *The Monstrous-Feminine* (1993), reading horror through Julia Kristeva's *Pouvoirs de l'horreur* (1980), located the genre's deepest anxiety in the maternal body: the archaic mother, the generative womb, the birth that horrifies. Red's monologue is organized as a maternal biography in two columns. Each event in the surface woman's reproductive life is paired with its subterranean debit—a medicated, surgical birth set against a solitary one; children conceived in a chosen marriage set against children conceived in a union the tether compelled, sex and pregnancy Red did not choose. It is the most explicit account in American horror of how the monstrous mother is made: by subtracting, one by one, every support the surface mother receives.

Kristeva's abject—that which must be expelled for the self to secure its borders—begins, in her account, with food loathing, the most elementary and archaic form of abjection. The film's dietary opposition, warm food above and raw rabbit below, is a Kristevan border drawn through the mouth. The Tethered eat what the surface abjects, and they are what the surface abjects.

Luce Irigaray's *Speculum de l'autre femme* (1974) reread Plato's cave as *hystera*, the womb, and the philosopher's ascent toward the sun as a repudiation of the maternal matrix from which he came. *Us* literalizes Irigaray's reading. The funhouse is a birth canal through which the underground-born girl is delivered, in 1986, into the light; the tunnels are a *hystera* the surface has forgotten it came from. The golden scissors acquire their obstetric meaning as the instrument that cuts the cord. The Untethering is a mass parturition, a nation delivered of its unacknowledged offspring, and the tether is legible as an umbilicus—a cord that nourishes in one direction only.

3.6 Flesh before body: Spillers

Hortense Spillers's "Mama's Baby, Papa's Maybe: An American Grammar Book" (1987), written against the Moynihan Report, distinguished the body, a subject position legible within civil and gendered order, from the flesh, the zero degree of social conceptualization to which captivity reduced the enslaved. Under captivity, Spillers argued, the female was ungendered. The protections gender nominally confers did not reach her: her body was open to her owner's sexual violence, and her children belonged to him under the colonial rule of *partus sequitur ventrem*, by which a child's status followed the mother's. Kinship lost its force, since any tie could be severed by sale. She called the marks of violence inscribed on captive flesh, and transmitted across generations, its hieroglyphics.

Red's life is legible in Spillers's grammar. She has no name, only a color; she wears a uniform that erases gender; her mate was assigned, and the tether compelled her into sex and pregnancy she did not choose: rape and forced reproduction, in plain terms. In the film's logic Abraham is compelled as she is; the agency belongs to the makers who

designed the tether, and it is set in motion, unknowingly, by the chosen marriage above. Her children were born without aid or right. Here the sororicidal foundation takes its sharpest form: the marriage and pregnancies the surface woman chose were enacted, without consent, on the body of the woman she displaced. Her throat carries the hieroglyph of 1986, a crushed larynx that writes the original violence into every word she speaks. Spillers suggested that the ungendered captive flesh might open the possibility of a relation to the female outside the patriarchal symbolic. Red's leadership—a woman commanding a movement of the voiceless without husband, title, or name—may be the film's single glimpse of that possibility, and it is broken at the neck.

3.7 The coerced dance: Foucault, Gottschild, Hartman

After the swap, the family's psychologist recommends that the silent child pursue dance as a means of expression, and ballet becomes the regimen through which she enters human legibility. Michel Foucault's *Surveiller et punir* (1975) described the disciplinary production of docile bodies through drill, posture, and the partition of gesture; classical ballet is among the most exacting disciplines of the body modernity has devised. Brenda Dixon Gottschild's *The Black Dancing Body* (2003) documented ballet's historical investment in an aesthetic of whiteness: its line, its verticality, its ethereal suppression of weight. The underground-born child becomes a woman through the most disciplined, most vertical, and historically whitest of bodily idioms, and the climactic intercutting of a girls' recital with the subterranean duel makes the cost visible.

Below, the tether forces the original to dance as the impostor dances: mirroring, untrained, in pain. Saidiya Hartman's *Scenes of Subjection* (1997) analyzed the "innocent amusements" of slavery—the coerced singing and dancing of captives in coffles and on the decks of slave ships—as performances in which domination masqueraded as pleasure and the line between enjoyment and violation was deliberately effaced. Red's subterranean dance is such a performance. Yet Hartman also attended to the practices through which the enslaved redirected coerced performance toward redress, and the film honors that possibility. In Red's telling, her dance below was the event through which the Tethered recognized her as different, as one who might lead. The same choreography is, above, the discipline that made a woman and, below, the revelation that made a prophet.

3.8 Imitation without original: Butler and Bhabha

Judith Butler's *Gender Trouble* (1990) theorized gender as performative, constituted through the stylized repetition of acts that produce the effect of an inner essence; "Imitation and Gender Insubordination" (1991) argued that gender is an imitation for which no original exists, the original being itself an effect of imitation. *Us* realizes Butler's thesis at the level of the person. The Tethered are the drag of the American family—costume, gesture, repetition—a mimicry so exact and so grotesque that it exposes the surface family's life as a set of repeated scripts. And the twist proves that an original can be produced by successful imitation: the copy, sufficiently practiced, became Adelaide.

Homi K. Bhabha's "Of Mimicry and Man" (1984) described colonial mimicry as the production of a subject that is almost the same, but not quite, whose resemblance is both the colonizer's desire and his menace, since it reveals the colonizer's identity as a performance that can be copied. The Tethered are Bhabha's mimics; their menace is their resemblance. The film's most acute portrait of femininity as mimicry belongs to the Tylers. Kitty's languid, cosmetically maintained, drink-glazed performance of white leisure is copied by her double, Dahlia, before a mirror with a lipstick, in a scene in which femininity appears as a rite performed with an instrument and a reflection. Kathryn Pauly Morgan's "Women and the Knife" (1991) analyzed cosmetic surgery as a colonization of women's bodies through an internalized gaze. Dahlia's grimacing rite, and her name, extend Morgan's analysis into horror. "Black Dahlia" was the press's name for Elizabeth Short, a twenty-two-year-old woman murdered in Los Angeles in January 1947, whose killer cut her face outward from the corners of the mouth into a fixed grin and mutilated her body; the killer was never identified. The double who smiles too widely bears the name of a woman whose smile was cut into her face. Femininity, in the Tylers' house, is already a cutting.

3.9 Eye to eye: Lorde

Audre Lorde's "Eye to Eye: Black Women, Hatred, and Anger" (1983) examined the hostility Black women direct at one another as the internalization of a hatred learned elsewhere—an anger meant for the world turned upon the nearest mirror. The climactic duel between two Black women who share a face is Lorde's essay externalized: sororicide as the form a structurally produced hatred takes when the structure is invisible and the sister is near.

"The Master's Tools Will Never Dismantle the Master's House" (1979) supplies a reading of the scissors. The Tethered's weapon is the emblem of the cut that created them; they propose to undo a severance with the instrument of severance, and Lorde's maxim predicts the outcome: the insurrection cuts, and the house stands. "The Uses of Anger" (1981) argued, against the demand that women of color manage their rage for

others' comfort, that anger is information and energy. Red's anger is the most lucid epistemology in the film. She alone knows what happened and what it cost, and her anger is the form that knowledge takes when no one will hear it.

3.10 Once upon a time: Red Riding Hood and the company of wolves

Red tells her history beside the hearth, the ancestral site of the old wives' tale. Marina Warner's *From the Beast to the Blonde* (1994) recovered the fairy tale as a genre of women's counter-knowledge, told by grandmothers, nurses, and servants and later appropriated by male collectors. Red reclaims the genre: a dispossessed woman's history told in the form the dispossessed have always used.

Her name points to the tale she tells. Charles Perrault's "Le Petit Chaperon rouge" (1697) and the Grimms' "Rotkäppchen" (1812) turn on an impostor in the place of kin: a wolf in the grandmother's bed, wearing her cap, and a child who scrutinizes the counterfeit body feature by feature. Jack Zipes's *The Trials and Tribulations of Little Red Riding Hood* (1983) argued that Perrault's and the Grimms' literary versions turned an oral tale of a resourceful girl into a cautionary fable about rape, a male fantasy in which the girl who strays from the path is made responsible for her own violation. In 1986 a little girl strayed from the path and was swallowed by her own wolf, and the wolf has worn her place ever since.

Angela Carter's "The Company of Wolves" (1979) rewrote the tale's ending. Carter's girl, faced with the wolf, laughs, undresses, and lies down between his paws; she refuses the role of prey by embracing her own wolfishness. The last scene of *Us* is the fairy tale's recognition dialogue without its dialogue. In the car Jason studies his mother as the child studies the figure in the bed—eyes, mouth, the sound she made below—and then lowers his werewolf mask over his face. Whether the gesture is concealment, solidarity, or initiation, the boy joins the company of wolves.

3.11 Toward a feminism of the umbilicus

Read through this genealogy, the feminism of *Us* is tragic. A patriarchal state—the anonymous makers, who copy bodies for the purpose of control and abandon them when the experiment fails—produces daughters and allots them a single place in the light. The film's women exercise agency in the only two forms that allotment permits, usurpation (Adelaide) and insurrection (Red), and each requires the other woman's death. Neither escapes the logic of the seat. What the film withholds, and what Chapter Seven attempts to formulate, is a third form: a feminism that treats the tether not as a chain to be cut nor as a leash to be seized, but as an umbilicus to be acknowledged—the scar of a common origin that obligates without binding.

CHAPTER FOUR

The Simulacral Insurrection: Plato's Cave, Deleuze's Reversal, and Trickle-Down Mimesis

4

The revolution is a remake of a charity broadcast.

The preceding chapters read the double through psychoanalysis, race, and gender. This chapter asks the ontological question those readings presuppose: what is the relation between an original and its copy, and what becomes of that relation when the copy takes the original's place? *Us* answers with a precision that places it in the line of Plato's *Republic*, Deleuze's *Logique du sens*, and Baudrillard's *Simulacres et simulation*.

4.1 The cave inverted

In Book VII of the *Republic* (514a–520a) Plato imagines prisoners chained from childhood in a cave, facing a wall on which they see only the shadows of objects carried before a fire behind them; they take the shadows for reality. One is freed, dragged up the steep ascent into the sun, and learns the truth; returning to free the others, he is mocked, and Socrates predicts that they would kill him if they could. *Us* retains the cave's architecture and inverts its terms. The Tethered are not watchers of shadows but shadows themselves—the film names one of them Umbrae, the Latin plural for "shadows"—and they do not perceive the surface they reflect; they enact it. The ascent occurs once, in 1986, but the one who ascends is the shadow, not the prisoner, and she never returns to free anyone. The one who returns in 2019 is the original, now a leader of shadows, and she brings not truth downward but shadows upward. Socrates' prediction is fulfilled with a twist: the one who would tell the truth is killed, but by the one who escaped.

The deepest inversion concerns the location of the original. For Plato the more real lies above: the sun, the Forms. In *Us* the original lies below and the copy reigns above. The vertical axis of value Plato established—height as reality, depth as illusion—is retained as a social fact and refuted as a metaphysical one.

4.2 Overturning Platonism: Deleuze's simulacrum

In "Platon et le simulacre," an appendix to *Logique du sens* (1969), Gilles Deleuze argued that the motivating task of Platonism is not to distinguish original from copy but good copies from bad: the icon, which resembles the Idea internally and is founded upon it, from the simulacrum, which produces an external effect of resemblance without internal relation to any model. Platonism is a politics of selection, a sorting of rival claimants. To overturn it, Deleuze proposed, is to let the simulacra rise and assert their rights among icons and copies; the simulacrum, far from a degraded copy, harbors a positive power that negates both original and copy, model and reproduction.

The twist of *Us* performs this overturning with diagrammatic exactness. A simulacrum rises to the surface, asserts its rights among the icons, and proves indistinguishable from them: the copy marries, mothers, and is loved; the original becomes the monster. The distinction between model and reproduction does not survive. What survives is position. Deleuze's overturned Platonism, transposed from ontology to politics, *is* positional personhood: once the sorting of claimants by their inner relation to an Idea collapses, the only criterion left for who counts is who stands where.

4.3 Depth and surface: Carroll, Artaud, and Red's voice

Logique du sens is also a book about depth and surface, and its tutelary author is Lewis Carroll. Deleuze observed that Alice's adventures begin as a descent into depths—the plunge down the rabbit-hole, among burrowing animals and devouring bodies—and give way to a play of surfaces: cards without thickness, a looking-glass world without depth. *Us* runs the white rabbit's trajectory in reverse. Its rabbits occupy the depths from the opening credits, caged in a wall of hutches; its looking-glass is a funhouse; its climactic movement is the ascent of the depths onto the surface.

Deleuze set Carroll's surface nonsense against the language of Antonin Artaud, a language of depths in which words collapse back into the body as cries and breaths. Red's voice belongs to Artaud. It is speech dragged up through a ruined throat, each word carrying the body's injury, sense audibly struggling against the depth from which it rises. The rest of the Tethered remain below sense altogether, in grunts and howls. Red is the hinge at which depth becomes surface and cry becomes narrative, and the film's horror and pathos both lie in hearing that passage occur.

4.4 Disneyland on the boardwalk: Baudrillard

Jean Baudrillard's *Simulacres et simulation* (1981) proposed that Disneyland is presented as imaginary in order to make us believe that the rest of America is real, when the surrounding America has passed into the order of the hyperreal. The Santa Cruz Beach Boardwalk performs Disneyland's function in *Us*. The funhouse is offered as an artificial space of fear so that the surrounding beach, houses, and families can pass as real. Yet the funhouse is the most real place in the film: it is the portal to the substrate on which the surface rests.

The boardwalk's signage records a revealing substitution. In 1986 the funhouse is called Shaman Vision Quest, its door crowned with appropriated Native American iconography; by 2019 the same building has been rebranded Merlin's Forest, its Indigenous kitsch replaced by an Arthurian wizard. The appropriation has been corrected at the level of the sign. The imperative beneath it, *Find Yourself*, is unchanged, and so is the portal. This is cosmetic decolonization: the replacement of one simulacrum by another while the structure the simulacrum concealed continues to operate. Its settler-colonial ground is examined in Chapter Five.

4.5 The spectacle of solidarity: Debord

Guy Debord's *La société du spectacle* (1967) defined the spectacle not as a collection of images but as a social relation among people mediated by images. Hands Across America was spectacle in Debord's precise sense: a social relation of solidarity mediated by the image of joined hands, broadcast nationally, enacted by participants who held strangers' hands for fifteen minutes and went home. The Untethering's final image belongs to the same order. The chain of red-clad bodies is seen from helicopters, which is to say from cameras; it is composed to be filmed. Even the revolt of those without images is captured as an image, and its power is the power of an image to which the surface has no reply.

4.6 The vertical cinema and its lineage

Us culminates a cinematic tradition of vertical class allegory. Fritz Lang's *Metropolis* (1927) placed its workers in subterranean shifts beneath the Eternal Gardens of the rich and produced, in the robot Maria, a female double who incites the workers to revolt; its closing intertitle insists that the mediator between head and hands must be the heart ("Mittler zwischen Hirn und Händen muss das Herz sein"). *Us* offers hands without head or heart: a chain of joined hands with no mediator. Douglas Cheek's *C.H.U.D.* (1984), whose box sits on the shelf in the film's first shot, imagined New York's unhoused mutated by toxic waste in the sewers, and a government concealing their existence. Wes Craven's *The People Under the Stairs* (1991) walled up stolen children inside a landlord couple's fortified house. Tobe Hooper's *The Texas Chain Saw Massacre* (1974), summoned by the name of Josh Tyler's double, Tex, concerned a family of slaughterhouse workers rendered obsolete by the mechanization of killing who turn their skills upon middle-class youth. Each film locates a population beneath or behind the bourgeois household. *Us* generalizes them into a geology and adds the element they lacked: the population below is the household itself.

4.7 Trickle-down mimesis

The concept announced in the Introduction can now be formalized. Trickle-down economics—the pejorative name for the supply-side program of the early Reagan administration, inaugurated by the Economic Recovery Tax Act of 1981—promised that wealth concentrated at the top would descend to those below. *Us* literalizes the promise and discloses its content. What descends from surface to depth is never substance but form. The Tethered receive the gestures of the surface without its goods: they lift food to their mouths when the surface eats, but the food is raw rabbit; they unwrap gifts when the surface unwraps gifts, but the gifts cut; they pair when the surface marries, but without choice; they dance when the surface dances, but in pain. Red's monologue is an inventory of forms without contents.

I call this structure *trickle-down mimesis*: the descent of form without content from an advantaged population to a deprived one, such that the deprived receive the shape of the advantaged life while its substance remains above. It is not exploitation in the classical sense, since nothing is extracted from below; it is a distribution in which one population receives a life and the other its silhouette.

Trickle-down mimesis has a corollary that governs the film's politics. If only forms descend, the forms available to the dispossessed for imagining their liberation are the forms of the advantaged. In 1986 two objects crossed the threshold in opposite directions. The commodity ascended: the *Thriller* T-shirt, worn up into the light by the girl who rose. The image descended: the Hands Across America advertisement, carried below in the memory of the girl who was taken. The insurrection is therefore shaped by

the only intact object the depths possessed, a television commercial. The revolution is a remake of a charity broadcast.

Fredric Jameson's "Reification and Utopia in Mass Culture" (1979) argued that mass culture manages real social anxieties and utopian longings, and that even the most degraded commodity carries a utopian kernel. The Tethered extract the kernel. Hands Across America promised, in the form of an advertisement, a continent joined hand to hand; the event itself was broken by gaps across the desert Southwest and dispersed within the quarter hour. The Tethered fulfil the advertisement literally and without interruption: the chain they raise across the hills is whole where the original was broken. The dispossessed take the commodity's promise at its word, and their literalism is their revenge.

CHAPTER FIVE

The Old Mole and the Accursed Share: The Political Economy of the Tether

5

The Tethered are the revolution as it appears to those who have spent their lives at the mallet.

If the Tethered produce nothing for the surface, in what sense is *Us* an economic allegory? This chapter answers through a sequence of materialist figures—Marx's alienated producer and surplus population, the "old mole" of subterranean revolution, Bataille's accursed share—and then situates the film's 1986 within the history of Reagan-era abandonment, the biopolitical management of superfluous life, and the settler-colonial ground of the California coast.

5.1 Alienation without labor: Marx

In the *Ökonomisch-philosophische Manuskripte* of 1844, Marx described four alienations of the worker under capital: from the product of labor, from the activity of labor, from species-being (*Gattungswesen*, the human capacity for free, conscious, self-directed activity), and from other human beings. The Tethered undergo a fifth alienation that completes the series: alienation from gesture itself. Their every movement belongs to another; they raise their arms because someone they have never seen raises his. This is alienation without labor, activity dispossessed even of its own initiation. Red's dance below, which the Tethered read as the sign of her difference, is the reclamation of species-being in Marx's sense: the first movement in the underground that originates in the mover's own will, even if its form was borrowed.

The chapter on commodity fetishism in *Capital* (1867) explained that social relations among producers appear, under capital, as relations among things, so that the producers' interdependence is concealed within the object. The surface comforts of *Us*—the warm meal, the soft gift, the beach house, the boat—appear as properties of things and of their owners. The tether is the concealed social relation: the dependence of one life's warmth upon another's cold, which the object's surface does not show.

Chapter 25 of *Capital* described the relative surplus population that accumulation necessarily produces—the industrial reserve army—and, at its lowest stratum, the pauperized "Lazarus-layers" (*Lazarusschichte*) of the working class, whose growth Marx called the absolute general law of capitalist accumulation. The Tethered are a surplus population in the strictest sense: produced for a purpose (control), rendered superfluous when that purpose failed, retained beneath the economy without employment. The opening card had already named them: infrastructure with no known purpose. Marx's figure is apt in a further register. Lazarus is the man raised from the dead. The Lazarus-layers of *Us* rise.

5.2 The old mole and the Whac-A-Mole covenant

The figure that unites Marx's revolutionary hope with the film's geology is the mole. In *Hamlet* (1.5), when the Ghost's voice cries "Swear!" from beneath the stage, Hamlet answers: "Well said, old mole! canst work i' th' earth so fast? / A worthy pioneer!" Hegel, in his *Lectures on the History of Philosophy*, borrowed the image for Spirit, which, seeming to have forgotten itself, works inwardly forward like the old mole beneath the ground until it breaks the crust. Marx, at the close of the *Eighteenth Brumaire* (1852), turned Hegel's Spirit into the revolution: when it has completed its preparatory work, Europe will leap from its seat and exult, "Brav gewühlt, alter Maulwurf!"—well grubbed, old mole! Georges Bataille's "The 'Old Mole' and the Prefix *Sur*" (c. 1929–30) set the mole against the eagle: against the Surrealists' Icarian idealism of the *sur-*, the above and the elevated, a base materialism that burrows in the low and the excluded.

Us places this lineage at its origin as a carnival game. On the boardwalk in 1986 the father plays Whac-A-Mole—a game in which creatures rise from holes and the player scores by beating them back down—and the prize the girl chooses is the *Thriller* T-shirt. I call this the *Whac-A-Mole covenant*: the ritual pact by which a society rewards the repression of what surfaces with a commodity. The prize, tellingly, is a costume of Black pop monstrosity. The game teaches its lesson at the very hour of the swap: the reward for keeping the moles down is a garment, and the girl who will wear it into the light is herself a mole that escaped the mallet.

When the film opened, the icon on that shirt was undergoing the operation the film describes. *Leaving Neverland*, Dan Reed's documentary in which Wade Robson and James Safechuck allege that Michael Jackson sexually abused them when they were boys, had aired on HBO less than three weeks before the film's release. Jackson had been acquitted of child-molestation charges in 2005, and his estate denies the allegations; Peele said he had not known the documentary would precede his film. The public argument that followed turned on whether testimony from below should displace the image above, and the garment the impostor wears into the light carried that argument into every screening.

The old mole of Shakespeare, Hegel, Marx, and Bataille is history working unseen until it breaks through; Whac-A-Mole is that figure domesticated as amusement. Us restores the old mole to its original meaning. The Tethered are the revolution as it appears to those who have spent their lives at the mallet.

5.3 The accursed share

Bataille's *La part maudite* (1949) reversed the premise of classical economics. The fundamental problem of a living system, Bataille argued, is not scarcity but excess: every system produces more energy than it needs to reproduce itself, and that surplus—the accursed share—must be expended, gloriously in sacrifice, festival, and luxury, or catastrophically in war. A society that refuses to acknowledge its accursed share will spend it anyway, as catastrophe.

The Tethered are the accursed share of American abundance: a surplus of life produced and then denied expenditure, stored underground like the excess Bataille warned could not be stored indefinitely. The Untethering is its catastrophic expenditure, the return of a surplus that the general economy declined to spend gloriously and that now spends itself in blood. Bataille's earlier heterology distinguished the homogeneous society of utility, measure, and production from the heterogeneous—the excremental, the sacred, the mad, the excluded, everything homogeneous society expels and cannot assimilate. The Tethered are the heterogeneous organized into a population.

Bataille's political imagination also supplies the final image with its form. Thomas Hobbes's *Leviathan* (1651) appeared beneath Abraham Bosse's frontispiece: a crowned giant towering over the land, his torso composed of hundreds of small human figures, the commonwealth as an artificial man whose head is the sovereign. Bataille's review *Acéphale* (1936–39) took as its emblem a headless man, sovereignty without a head. The Tethered chain across the California hills is an acephalic Leviathan: a body politic composed of human figures, laid horizontally across the land rather than raised vertically over it, with no crown and no head. Its leader is dead before it forms. It is sovereignty as pure collective form, without a sovereign.

5.4 Hands Across America and the economy of the gesture

On 25 May 1986 some six and a half million people joined hands along a line from New York to Long Beach, California, for fifteen minutes, in a benefit for hunger and homelessness organized by USA for Africa, the organization behind "We Are the World." The event's genre was the gesture. It fell well short of its projected receipts, a substantial share of what it raised was consumed by the cost of staging it, and its line was broken by long gaps where the country was empty of participants.

It belonged to a decade in which the Reagan administration's budgets, enacted with Congress, sharply reduced federal housing assistance; in which President Reagan signed the Omnibus Budget Reconciliation Act of 1981, repealing most of the Mental Health Systems Act that President Carter had signed in 1980 and folding federal mental-health funding into reduced block grants; and in which homelessness became a visible condition of American cities on a scale unseen since the Depression. Its causes were plural, and historians weigh them differently: deinstitutionalization had begun in the 1950s, and rising rents, the demolition of single-room-occupancy housing, and recession all contributed. The film's point concerns the decade's response, which was a gesture. The man on the boardwalk who holds a cardboard sign reading *Jeremiah* 11:11 belongs to that decade's abandoned. His double, in 2019, stands on the beach in a red jumpsuit with bleeding hands outstretched, an image of stigmata and crucifixion that rhymes with the outstretched hands of the human chain.

Us reads Hands Across America as the decade's emblem of humanitarianism as gesture: solidarity enacted by the joined hands of the comfortable while the hands of the abandoned went empty. Red's restaging restores the gesture's missing referent. The hands are now those of the dispossessed, and the line passes not through the comfortable but over their bodies.

5.5 Make live and let die: biopolitics, bare life, death-worlds

Michel Foucault's 1976 lectures, "*Il faut défendre la société*," described the modern transformation of sovereign power from the right to take life or let live into the biopolitical power to make live and let die, and identified racism as the mechanism that introduces a caesura into the biological continuum of a population, dividing those to be fostered from those to be abandoned. The Tethered are the *let die* in its purest administrative form: not killed but left, the experiment abandoned, the population sealed below with rabbits for food.

Giorgio Agamben's *Homo Sacer* (1995) argued that Western sovereignty constitutes itself through the inclusive exclusion of bare life (*zoē*), life included in the political order only through its exposure to abandonment, as opposed to the qualified life (*bios*) of the citizen. The tether is the inclusive exclusion made physical: the Tethered are bound to citizens and excluded from citizenship, inside the nation's body and outside its law. Agamben's paradigm for that exclusion is the camp, which he called the hidden matrix of modern political space: a zone opened when the state of exception becomes the rule, its extreme instance the Nazi concentration camp. The white-tiled underground is a camp in this technical sense, a space built by the state and placed outside the law, in which life is held without rights; the analogy is structural and does not equate the film's fiction with that history. In *L'aperto* (2002) Agamben described the anthropological machine that produces the human by separating it from the animal within, either by animalizing the human or by humanizing the animal. His own examples are exact: the

ancient machine produced the slave, the barbarian, and the foreigner as animals in human form; the modern machine produced the Jew, in the Nazi camp, as the non-human within the human. The anonymous makers of *Us* built an anthropological machine in the literal sense, and its product is a population of humans animalized: raw-meat eaters, grunters, shufflers, living among rabbits.

Achille Mbembe's "Necropolitics" (2003) extended Foucault toward the colony and the plantation, describing death-worlds in which vast populations are subjected to conditions of life that confer on them the status of the living dead. The white-tiled corridors of the underground—a school, a clinic, a playground, a dormitory, each a parody—constitute a death-world in Mbembe's sense: an institutional architecture of life emptied of life's substance.

Ruth Wilson Gilmore's *Golden Gulag* (2007) documented California's unprecedented prison expansion from the early 1980s and defined racism as the production and exploitation, by the state or outside the law, of a vulnerability to premature death differentiated by group. The state that built the Golden Gulag is the state in which *Us* is set; its uniformed population is the historical referent of the red coverall; and the Tethered's golden scissors may be read, in Gilmore's light, as the Golden State's emblem returned to it by those it consigned to premature death.

5.6 The ground beneath the tunnels: the settler-colonial substrate

The film's dyads—surface and depth, Wilson and Tyler, Black and white—rest on ground that belongs to neither party. The opening card's deserted mine shafts evoke the Gold Rush, whose extractive boom from 1848 coincided with what Benjamin Madley's *An American Genocide* (2016) documents as genocide: the killing of California's Indigenous peoples between 1846 and 1873 by vigilantes, state militias, and U.S. Army units, in campaigns funded by the state of California and largely reimbursed by the federal government. The state's first elected governor, Peter Burnett, told the legislature in 1851: "That a war of extermination will continue to be waged between the races until the Indian race becomes extinct, must be expected." Santa Cruz was founded as a Spanish mission in 1791 on the lands of Awaswas-speaking Ohlone peoples, whom the mission system confined, compelled to labor, and punished with flogging. In 1812 Indigenous people held at the mission killed its priest, Andrés Quintana; in the account Lorenzo Asisara, whose father was among them, gave the historian Thomas Savage in 1877, Quintana had begun punishing people with a whip tipped with metal. The depth has risen against the surface on this ground before. The funhouse's 1986 name and iconography, Shaman Vision Quest, conscripted a caricature of Indigenous religion into amusement; its 2019 rebranding as Merlin's Forest removed the caricature without restoring anything. The signage thus records a three-stage history of the settler relation to land: dispossession, appropriation, erasure.

Two cautions follow. Glen Sean Coulthard's *Red Skin, White Masks* (2014), adapting Fanon, argued that the liberal politics of recognition reproduces colonial power by offering Indigenous peoples recognition on terms set by the settler state; the boardwalk's correction of its sign is recognition of exactly this kind, a gesture toward the injured that leaves the land where it lies. And Eve Tuck and K. Wayne Yang's "Decolonization Is Not a Metaphor" (2012) warned against absorbing Indigenous dispossession into metaphors for other injustices, a settler move to innocence that converts land into allegory. A reading that calls the Tethered "colonized" risks that move, and this dissertation declines to make it. The point is narrower and harder: beneath the vertical drama of surface and depth lies a horizontal dispossession that the film acknowledges only in a sign, and that no rearrangement of above and below would repair.

5.7 Specters, hosts, and a machine named Ophelia

Jacques Derrida's *Spectres de Marx* (1993) began from Hamlet's "The time is out of joint" and proposed a hauntology in place of ontology: an ethics and politics of living with ghosts—the dead, the unborn, the not-yet-present—who make claims of justice upon the living. *Us* is set in households haunted by their own specters, one of them equipped with a domestic machine named after Hamlet's drowned madwoman. When Josh Tyler, under attack, orders the smart speaker Ophelia to call the police, it plays N.W.A.'s "Fuck tha Police" (1988). The gag is the film's most efficient political joke and its most precise Freudian slip: a white household's infrastructure, asked to summon the state's armed protection, answers with N.W.A.'s Compton anthem against the racial profiling and beating of young Black men by Los Angeles police, a practice that the filmed beating of Rodney King by LAPD officers made notorious three years later. Elaine Showalter's "Representing Ophelia" (1985) traced Ophelia's career as Western culture's archetype of feminine madness. Peele's Ophelia is a madwoman in the machine, and her one act of speech is the return of a repressed voice.

Derrida's later seminars on hospitality (*De l'hospitalité*, 1997) drew on Émile Benveniste's demonstration that Latin *hostis* (enemy, stranger) and *hospes* (host, guest) share a root, so that the guest is always potentially the enemy; Derrida named the conjunction *hostipitality*. The Wilsons are hosts to the most intimate of guests, and the guests are enemies, because the intruders are the household's own kin.

Mark Fisher's *The Weird and the Eerie* (2016) defined the eerie as a failure of absence or of presence—something where there should be nothing, or nothing where there should be something—and identified capital as an eerie entity, conjured from nothing yet more influential than any substantial being. The tunnels without known purpose are eerie in Fisher's sense, and so are the Tethered: an agency no one authored, at work where no one looks. Slavoj Žižek's *Looking Awry* (1991) asked why the dead return in popular culture and answered that they return because they were not properly buried,

because a symbolic debt remains unpaid. The Tethered are the improperly buried. They come back to collect.

CHAPTER SIX

Covenant, Binding, Substitution: The Political Theology of the Tether

6

The trickster becomes the priest; Br'er Rabbit becomes Abraham.

Us announces its theology before its plot. Among the first figures the girl passes on the boardwalk in 1986 is a man holding a cardboard sign that reads *Jeremiah* 11:11, and the reference returns in 2019 as the hour of the invasion. This chapter reads the film's scriptural and mythic substrate—Jeremiah's broken covenant and its American afterlife in John Winthrop, the binding of Isaac, the briar patch, Aristophanes' severed humans, the Fates' shears, Ovid's Io—and argues that together they compose a political theology of substitution: a doctrine of who may stand in whose stead, and at what price. It closes with an onomastics of the tether.

6.1 Jeremiah 11:11 and the inverted Exodus

The verse reads, in the King James Version: "Therefore thus saith the LORD, Behold, I will bring evil upon them, which they shall not be able to escape; and though they shall cry unto me, I will not hearken unto them." Its context is a broken covenant. The chapter opens with a curse upon "the man that obeyeth not the words of this covenant" (11:3), a covenant made "in the day that I brought them forth out of the land of Egypt, from the iron furnace" (11:4). The covenant was founded on an exodus, and its breach is punished by an evil from which, in the Hebrew, they "will not be able to go out" (*lo yukhlu latset mimmennah*). *Latset* is the infinitive of *yatsa*, the verb of the Exodus itself, the going-out from Egypt. Jeremiah's sanction is an anti-Exodus: those once brought out of the iron furnace will be shut inside an evil with no way out.

Us distributes the verse's two movements across its two populations. The surface, having broken a covenant it never knew it had made, is shut inside a night without exit, its cries unheard; when the Tylers' machine is asked to call the police, it does not hearken. The depth, meanwhile, performs the Exodus the verse denies the covenant-breakers: the Tethered go out from their iron furnace. The second clause

carries the film's sharpest irony. The surface had never hearkened to the cry from below. Its punishment is a symmetry of the ear: its own cry is now the one that goes unheard.

The chapter's sequel deepens the resonance. Jeremiah learns that the men of his own town, Anathoth, are plotting his death (11:21), and is warned: "even thy brethren, and the house of thy father, even they have dealt treacherously with thee" (12:6). The prophet's enemies are his kin. So are the Wilsons'.

6.2 A city upon a hill: Winthrop's hypogeal covenant

Jeremiah's covenant has an American translation. John Winthrop's "A Model of Christian Charity," composed in 1630 for the colonists of Massachusetts Bay, is a founding text of American covenant theology, and it opens with a theology of vertical distribution: "God Almighty in his most holy and wise providence hath so disposed of the condition of mankind, as in all times some must be rich, some poor, some high and eminent in power and dignity; others mean and in subjection." Inequality is providential; what binds the high to the low is charity. "We must be knit together in this work as one man," Winthrop urged; "we must delight in each other, make others' conditions our own, rejoice together, mourn together, labor and suffer together." The covenant's sanction is public exposure: "we shall be as a city upon a hill. The eyes of all people are upon us"—and if we deal falsely, "we shall be made a story and a by-word through the world."

This is the covenant from which this dissertation takes its title. A *hypogeal covenant* presupposes the high and the low, binds them as one body, and charges the high with making the conditions of the low their own. The Tethered are Winthrop's "mean and in subjection," and the surface has broken the covenant less by oppressing them than by forgetting them. Hands Across America is Winthrop's knitting reduced to fifteen minutes. The decade's president, Ronald Reagan, made Winthrop's city his signature figure and added the adjective "shining"; *Us* sets its first act in that shining city and digs beneath it. Winthrop's *us*—the covenanted community upon which the eyes of all people rest—is the first *us* of American political theology. Peele's is its last: a community become a story and a by-word, upon which the eyes of its own buried members are now fixed.

Robert N. Bellah's "Civil Religion in America" (1967) showed how the Exodus typology of a chosen people bound by covenant persisted in American public life. *Us* is a work of civil-religious horror. It takes the covenant seriously enough to imagine its curse.

6.3 Jeremiah 11:19: the lamb and the erased name

Eight verses later Jeremiah describes himself as the object of his kinsmen's plot: "But I was like a lamb or an ox that is brought to the slaughter; and I knew not that they had devised devices against me, saying, Let us destroy the tree with the fruit thereof, and let us cut him off from the land of the living, that his name may be no more remembered." The verse contains the film in miniature. The lamb brought to slaughter is the rabbit in its cage. To *cut off* is the scissors' work. And the purpose of the cutting—"that his name may be no more remembered"—is fulfilled in the antagonist, who has lost her name entirely and is known only by a color, while her name walks the surface on another woman.

6.4 The numerology of 11:11

The film's chosen verse doubles itself. The numeral 11:11 is four upright strokes in two identical pairs divided by a colon: four figures standing in a row, joined at the center by a tether, the visual form of the family that appears in the driveway at that hour. It is a palindrome, legible in a mirror, and the hour at which, in contemporary vernacular superstition, one makes a wish. The surface wishes at 11:11; the depth arrives. Jung would have called the convergence synchronicity. The film calls it an appointment.

6.5 The binding: the Akedah and the ram

Genesis 22 narrates the episode Jewish tradition calls the Akedah, the binding: Abraham "laid the wood in order, and bound Isaac his son, and laid him on the altar upon the wood" (22:9). The Hebrew verb, *vayya'aqod*, from the root *ʿ-q-d*, gives the episode its name. The Tethered are, etymologically, the Bound, and the film assigns Gabe's double the name of the patriarch who bound his son.

The Akedah is a narrative of substitution. As Abraham raises the knife an angel stays his hand, and "behold behind him a ram caught in a thicket by his horns: and Abraham went and took the ram, and offered him up for a burnt offering in the stead of his son" (22:13). *In the stead of*: the ram dies so that the son may live. Søren Kierkegaard's *Fear and Trembling* (1843) read Abraham's willingness as the teleological suspension of the ethical, the subordination of universal moral law to a higher end. The anonymous makers of *Us* are an Abraham without an angel. They bound their creations for an end beyond the ethical—control—and, when the end failed, left them bound on the altar. No ram was provided. The Tethered are Isaacs who were never unbound.

6.6 Two thickets: the ram and the rabbit

The film therefore contains two thickets and two theories of substitution. In Abraham's thicket the ram is caught and offered in another's stead: *sacrificial substitution*, in which a life is spent so that an order may continue. In Br'er Rabbit's briar patch the rabbit, begging not to be thrown into the thorns, is thrown, and escapes into the place where he was bred and born: *fugitive substitution*, in which the weak exchange places with their fate by cunning.

The swap of 1986 is fugitive substitution. The underground girl escapes by inversion, as the trickster does, trading her place for another's. The killing of 2019 is sacrificial substitution. Red, caught in the tunnels as the ram in the thicket, is offered in the stead of the surface order. The moral arc of *Us* is the conversion of the first kind of substitution into the second: the trickster becomes the priest; Br'er Rabbit becomes Abraham. The conversion takes place on the trickster's home ground. When Adelaide descends through the funhouse in pursuit of her son, she returns to the briar patch where she was bred and born, moves through it with a native's knowledge, and makes it an altar.

6.7 Aristophanes' navel and Atropos' shears

In Plato's *Symposium* (189c–193d) Aristophanes tells of the original humans: round, four-armed, four-legged, two-faced, so strong that they assailed the gods. Zeus cut them in two, as Jowett's translation has it, "as you might divide an egg with a hair." Apollo turned each half's face toward the wound, drew the skin together over the belly like a purse with a drawstring, and tied it at the navel, leaving a few wrinkles there "as a memorial of the primeval state." Ever since, each half has sought its other; Eros is the name of that seeking.

Us restages Aristophanes with two amendments. The cut was made by human makers, not a god; and the halves seek one another not for union but for replacement, so that Eros becomes rivalry. Yet Aristophanes' navel survives as the most hopeful figure the film's logic allows. It is the knot left by the cut, a memorial that the halves were once one. The tether is a navel stretched into a cord. The ethics formulated in Chapter Seven is an ethics of the navel: neither the reversal of the cut nor its repetition, but its remembrance.

Greek myth assigned the cutting of lives to the Moirai: Clotho spins the thread, Lachesis measures it, and Atropos—"she who cannot be turned"—cuts it with her shears. The golden scissors place Atropos's instrument in the hands of those whose thread the surface had measured out. The emblem is exact in a further respect. Scissors are two blades joined at a pivot, and neither blade cuts alone; the instrument of severance is itself a tethered pair. The Tethered carry the paradox of their condition in their hands. They can sever only as a couple.

6.8 Io: writing in the dust

In the first book of Ovid's *Metamorphoses* (c. 8 CE), Jupiter pursues Io, halts her flight under a cloud, and rapes her—*rapuitque pudorem*, in Ovid's words (1.600)—then turns her into a heifer to hide what he has done from Juno. When she tries to speak she can only low. Before her father, the river-god Inachus, she traces her name with her hoof in the dust—*littera pro verbis*, letters instead of words—and is recognized. One of the Tyler twins' doubles is named Io. The myth gives the film's figure of the voiceless woman a scene of inscription: identity recovered through writing when speech has been taken. Io loses her voice to the transformation by which the god who raped her hides his crime; Red lost hers to the girl who replaced her, and her monstrousness hides that crime. Red's fairy tale is a hoofprint in the dust offered to a listener who must decide whether to recognize her.

Michel Foucault closed *Les mots et les choses* (1966) with the prediction that man, a recent invention, might be erased like a face drawn in sand at the edge of the sea. The beach at Santa Cruz is the film's site of inscription and erasure: the surface writes its leisure in the sand, a frisbee settles on a printed circle, and the tide from below comes in.

6.9 Covenant into contract: Mills and Baldwin

Modern political philosophy secularized the covenant as a contract: Hobbes, Locke, and Rousseau grounded political obligation in an agreement among equals. Charles W. Mills's *The Racial Contract* (1997) argued that the actual contract underwriting modern polities was a racial one, dividing humanity into persons and sub-persons and requiring of its signatories an epistemology of ignorance—a structured, socially functional inability to understand the world they themselves had made. The surface of *Us* lives under a contract of exactly this kind. Its beneficiaries did not sign it, do not know its terms, and profit from them; their ignorance is not a lapse but a clause.

James Baldwin, in the letter to his nephew that opens *The Fire Next Time* (1963), located the crime of white America in its innocence: its refusal to know what it had done and was doing. Baldwin took his title from a spiritual's promise of fire after the flood, and *Us* gives its fire to Pluto, whom Jason, realizing that his double mirrors him, leads backward into a burning car. Baldwin's indictment is the theological core of the ending. The Tylers die innocent in Baldwin's sense; the Wilsons survive in it; Adelaide, who alone is not innocent, chooses innocence in the final shot by smiling. The film's last question is whether innocence, once lost, can be chosen again.

6.10 An onomastics of the tether

The film's names form a system. The surface families bear names drawn from scripture, letters, and the suburbs; their doubles bear names drawn from cosmology, myth, and the underworld.

Adelaide derives from the Old High German *Adalheidis*: *adal*, "noble," and *heit*, "kind" or "sort." Her maiden name, *Thomas*, derives from the Aramaic for "twin." The Fourth Gospel calls the apostle "Thomas, which is called Didymus," the Greek for twin (John 11:16), and gives him his line on the road to the tomb of Lazarus; the same Thomas refused to believe in the risen body until he could see in its hands "the print of the nails" (John 20:25). The woman born underground took by theft a name that means *the noble kind of twin*. Her son, in the final scene, plays doubting Thomas, examining the body that has returned from below for its proof; the film had already shown him, on the beach, a man whose hands bled. Her married name, Wilson, joins her to Poe.

Gabe (Gabriel, angel of the annunciation) is doubled by Abraham, patriarch of the binding. Zora, who bears Hurston's name, is doubled by Umbrae, the shadows; in astronomy the umbra is the darkest region of a shadow during an eclipse. Jason—a name the slasher canon assigns to Jason Voorhees, the drowned boy avenged in *Friday the 13th* (1980) by his murderous mother—is doubled by Pluto, Roman lord of the underworld, whose Greek name, *Plouton*, means wealth: the riches beneath the earth. The celestial Pluto was removed from the category of planet by the International Astronomical Union in 2006, a taxonomic expulsion that rhymes with the Tethered's expulsion from the category of person.

Josh and Kitty Tyler are doubled by Tex, after Hooper's displaced slaughterhouse family, and Dahlia, after the murdered "Black Dahlia" of 1947. Their twin daughters are doubled by Io (Ovid's heifer, and a moon of Jupiter) and Nix (named for Nyx, primordial Night, and a moon of Pluto). The household machine is Ophelia. The antagonist alone has no name, only a color: Red—of blood, of the revolutionary flag, of Jackson's jacket, of the hood the wolf found on the forest path, and of the color scheme of race in which settler America called Indigenous peoples "red," the grammar Wilderson adopts when he names the Native position Red. The name does not make Red Indigenous; it places her in the oldest American scheme for ranking people by color, beside the white Tylers and the Black Wilsons.

CHAPTER SEVEN

Toward a Hypogeal Humanism

7

The human is not the one who stands, but the one who knows on what, and on whom, she stands.

The preceding chapters established the film's diagnostic content. This chapter turns normative. It passes the humanist tradition and its critics through the film, marks where each fails to account for the tether, and formalizes the alternative that the film implies but withholds.

7.1 The humanist inheritance and its scission

Giovanni Pico della Mirandola's *Oratio de hominis dignitate* (1486) gave Renaissance humanism its founding myth. Having assigned every other creature a fixed nature, God addresses Adam as a being without a determinate seat, form, or office, free to degenerate into the brutes below or to be reborn into the divine above, according to the judgment of his own spirit. Pico's human is self-fashioning, the chameleon of creation. The underground-born Adelaide is the most perfectly Pichian figure in modern cinema: she rose from the condition of the brutes—raw meat, grunts, mimicry—to speech, dance, love, and family by her own exertion. But Pico's ladder in *Us* has two climbers and one rung. Self-fashioning is a zero-sum ascent; her rising was another's fall. Transposed into a world of positions, Pico's dignity becomes a competition for a single seat.

Kant gave humanism its moral law. The *Groundwork of the Metaphysics of Morals* (1785), in T. K. Abbott's translation, commands: "So act as to treat humanity, whether in thine own person or in that of any other, in every case as an end withal, never as means only." The Tethered were made as means only—instruments of control—and then abandoned as not even means. Kantian dignity rests on rational autonomy, a capacity the surface presumes the Tethered to lack, since they only mimic. Red's planning, oratory, and leadership refute the presumption, and with it the boundary Kant's dignity requires.

Kant's essay of 1784 defines Enlightenment as "der Ausgang des Menschen aus seiner selbstverschuldeten Unmündigkeit"—humanity's exit from its self-incurred minority. Three words bear on the film. *Ausgang* is an exit, a way out. *Selbstverschuldet*, self-incurred, is exactly what the Tethered's condition is not: their minority was incurred by others, and Kant's formula, addressing only self-incurred immaturity, leaves them outside the Enlightenment's address. *Unmündigkeit*, the inability to speak and act for oneself, derives etymologically from *Munt*, guardianship, but sounds in German like the absence of a mouth, *Mund*. Red's mouth was crushed. The Untethering is an *Ausgang* the Enlightenment did not foresee, an exit from a minority incurred by others, and it converges with Jeremiah's *latset*: both name the going-out.

Jean-Paul Sartre's *L'existentialisme est un humanisme* (1946) declared that existence precedes essence: the human is nothing but what it makes of itself. Adelaide is the existentialist heroine par excellence, a being without essence who made herself; but her freedom was purchased with another's facticity. Simone de Beauvoir's *Le deuxième sexe* (1949) argued that one becomes, rather than is born, a woman. Adelaide becomes a woman, and a human, through a regimen of feminine formation—therapy, ballet, marriage, motherhood. Beauvoir's woman is constituted as Other to man; Adelaide's Other is a woman. Martin Heidegger's "Brief über den Humanismus" (1947) called language the house of Being and rejected the metaphysical humanism that defines the human as a rational animal. Red dwells in language as in a ruin, a house of Being whose walls were broken in childhood, and the film asks whether Being can be housed in a rasp.

7.2 The counter-humanist indictment

The twentieth century prosecuted humanism from several directions. Foucault, as noted, predicted the erasure of "man" like a face in sand. Sartre's preface to *Les damnés de la terre* (1961) denounced European humanism as an ideology of lies, a justification for pillage. Aimé Césaire's *Discours sur le colonialisme* (1950) indicted Europe's pseudo-humanism as narrow, fragmentary, and racist, and called for a humanism made to the measure of the world. Fanon closed *Les damnés* by summoning his readers to work out new concepts and set afoot a new humanity. Edward Said's *Humanism and Democratic Criticism* (2004) redefined humanism as critique: the practice of exposing what a canon of the human excludes.

Sylvia Wynter's "Unsettling the Coloniality of Being/Power/Truth/Freedom" (2003) is the most consequential of these interventions for the present argument. Wynter argued that the West's descriptive statement of the human—first as Man1, the rational political subject of the Renaissance and Enlightenment, then as Man2, the bio-economic subject of the nineteenth century onward—has been overrepresented as if it were the human itself, and that each version requires its Others. For Man2, Wynter argued, the ultimate referent of those cast as dysselected by nature and the market is

the Black person of African descent, with the jobless, the homeless, and the poor ranged beside that figure. Against this Wynter proposed that humans are hybrid beings of *bios* and *mythoi*, a storytelling species that institutes its genres of the human through origin narratives.

Red's "Once upon a time" is a counter-origin narrative. It composes from below a new descriptive statement in which the human appears as the one who was given warm food because another was given raw rabbit. The Tethered are a genre of the human that had not been narrated, and Red narrates it.

Emmanuel Levinas's *Totalité et infini* (1961) and *Humanisme de l'autre homme* (1972) grounded ethics in the face of the Other, whose nakedness issues the command not to kill and who addresses me from a dimension of height. Levinas called the result a humanism of the other man. *Us* presents it with two challenges. First, the Other's face is my face: the alterity Levinas presupposes collapses into identity, and the command not to kill becomes either narcissism or, as in Poe, a suicide the killer survives. Second, the Other comes not from height but from depth. Hypogeal humanism replaces Levinas's altitudinal ethics, in which the Other commands from above, with an ethics in which the Other sustains from below. The Other's claim on me is not a command but a debt.

7.3 Posthumanisms and the fractal below

Donna Haraway's "A Cyborg Manifesto" (1985) described the cyborg as the illegitimate offspring of militarism and patriarchal capitalism and argued that illegitimate offspring tend to be unfaithful to their origins. The Tethered are illegitimate offspring of a state program, and they are unfaithful to their makers. But trickle-down mimesis keeps them faithful to the surface's forms. The posthumanist promise—a hybrid that escapes the categories of its production—is checked by the film: the hybrid escapes its makers but not its models.

Rosi Braidotti's *The Posthuman* (2013) proposed a zoe-centred egalitarianism, affirming *zoē* not as Agamben's abandoned bare life but as generative vitality shared across species. The Tethered are *zoē* in Agamben's sense compelled to mimic *bios*; Braidotti's affirmation would require that their life be valued as life rather than as a failed copy of citizenship.

The rabbits press the posthumanist question furthest. The credits open on a wall of caged rabbits; the Tethered live among them and eat them raw. Richard Adams's *Watership Down* (1972) imagined Cowslip's warren, whose sleek, artistic rabbits are fed by a farmer who snares them and have agreed never to speak of the wire; their culture rests on an unspoken arrangement with death. The surface of *Us* is Cowslip's warren. But the rabbits also stand beneath the Tethered, and the structure repeats: the hypogeal is fractal, and every below has its below. Jacques Derrida's *L'animal que donc je suis* (2006) began from the gaze of an animal that sees the philosopher naked; the

rabbits' gaze presides over the film's opening credits. A humanism that stops at the species line repeats the structure it claims to criticize.

7.4 Feminist relational ontology: the tether as umbilicus

Feminist philosophy supplies what the humanist and posthumanist traditions lack. Bracha L. Ettinger's *The Matrixial Borderspace* (2006) theorized a non-phallic dimension of subjectivity modeled on the late-prenatal encounter between a becoming-mother and a becoming-infant: co-emergence in differentiation, a borderlinking of partial subjects who share traces without fusing or expelling one another. Read matrixially, the tether is not a chain of control but a string of co-emergence. Judith Butler's *Precarious Life* (2004) and *Frames of War* (2009) argued that bodies are constitutively exposed to and dependent upon others, that we are undone by one another from the start, and that frames of recognition decide which lives count as grievable. The Tethered are ungrievable lives; the film's dead are mourned unequally, and its spectators cheer some deaths. Eva Feder Kittay's *Love's Labor* (1999) placed dependency at the center of political philosophy, insisting that each of us is some mother's child and that justice must account for those who care for the dependent. Carol Gilligan's *In a Different Voice* (1982) and Nel Noddings's *Caring* (1984) articulated ethics as care within relation.

Us tests care ethics severely. Its two mothers practice care in its most partisan form; each kills for her children. Care that does not acknowledge the tether becomes tribal. The feminist relational tradition nonetheless supplies hypogeal humanism with its central image. The tether is an umbilicus. An umbilicus is neither chain nor leash; it is the cord through which one life nourishes another before either is separate, and its cutting leaves a navel—Aristophanes' knot—that memorializes a dependence older than autonomy. The golden scissors are obstetric. The question the film poses is not whether to cut, but what to do with the navel.

7.5 Four responses to the tether

The film's possible responses to the tether can be arranged on two axes: whether the relation to the double is severed or retained, and whether the distribution of standing is preserved or reorganized. The four combinations exhaust the film's moral field.

Severance with preserved standing is *exorcism*: the surface kills the depth and keeps its place. This is Adelaide's act in the tunnels, the Whac-A-Mole covenant enacted by hand. Severance with reorganized standing is *reversal*: the depth kills the surface and takes its place. This is Red's Untethering and the primal swap generalized, Fanon's first moment of decolonization. Retention with preserved standing is *integration*: the shadow is acknowledged and the arrangement kept. This is the therapeutic and liberal option, Jung's integration of the shadow and Hands Across America's fifteen minutes of

contact. Retention with reorganized standing is *acknowledgment*: the relation is kept and the standing changed. The film shows the first three. It withholds the fourth.

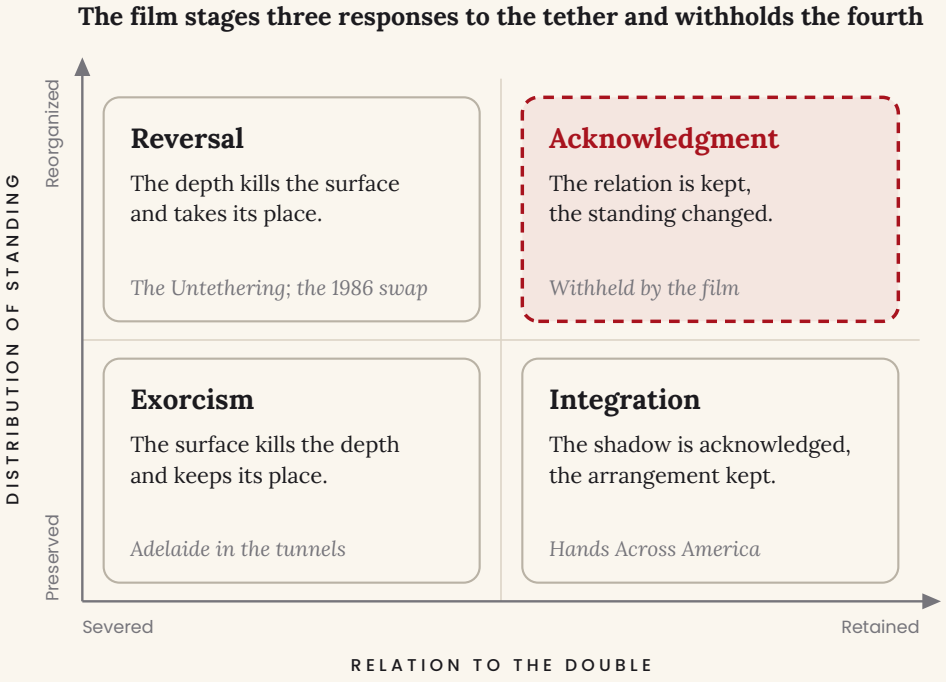


Figure 1. Four responses to the tether, arranged on two axes.

Exorcism and reversal both cut the tether; integration keeps it but leaves standing where it was. Only acknowledgment keeps the relation and changes who stands where, and it is the one response the film withholds.

7.6 The four axioms of hypogeal humanism

Axiom I: Position. The human is a position, not a property. Humanity—speech, comfort, recognition, a name—is conferred by location within a distribution, and every location is contestable. The axiom follows from the twist and from the Deleuzian overturning of Platonism, and it separates hypogeal humanism from every humanism of essence, whether theological (Pico), rational (Kant), or existential (Sartre), since each locates the human in a capacity rather than a place.

Axiom II: Nourishment. Every position of standing is hypogeally nourished. Flourishing above is the expenditure of life below; there is no shoot without cotyledons. The axiom follows from Red's two-columned monologue, from Marx's concealed social relation, and from Bataille's accursed share. It is fractal: the nourishing below has its own below, and the debt does not stop at the species line.

Axiom III: Substitution. Every occupant of standing holds her place by an originary substitution that she must forget and is compelled to repeat. Forgetting is not an accident of standing but its condition. The axiom follows from Adelaide's amnesia and its return, from Freud's melancholia and repetition compulsion, from Spivak's sororicidal foundation, and from Mills's epistemology of ignorance.

Axiom IV: Acknowledgment. The ethical act is neither severance, nor reversal, nor integration, but acknowledgment: the anamnestic solidarity by which the one who stands remembers the one on whom she stands and reorganizes her standing accordingly. The term is Johann Baptist Metz's. In *Glaube in Geschichte und Gesellschaft* (1977), Metz described a solidarity in memory with the dead and the vanquished, and the dangerous memory of suffering that interrupts the history told by the victors. Walter Benjamin's seventh thesis on the concept of history (1940) had stated the principle in its starkest form: "Es ist niemals ein Dokument der Kultur, ohne zugleich ein solches der Barbarei zu sein"—there is no document of culture that is not at the same time a document of barbarism. Adelaide's final flashback is dangerous memory in Metz's sense; her smile is its suppression.

The four axioms yield a single formula: *the human is not the one who stands, but the one who knows on what, and on whom, she stands.* Acknowledgment in this sense is not an apology, a recitation, or a fifteen-minute gesture. It is a reorganization of standing, material rather than merely symbolic. In the film's own terms it would mean the surface ceding what it holds: sharing the warm meal, the soft gift, the assisted birth, the sun.

7.7 Objections and replies

The Afropessimist objection holds that any humanism re-inscribes the Human, the very category constituted by antiblackness, and that reconciliation is the liberal fantasy Afropessimism exists to refuse. The reply is that hypogeal humanism does not restore the Human's coherence; it defines humanity by debt rather than dignity, and it promises no reconciliation. It accepts antagonism as fact while declining to ontologize it as destiny. Its human is not the Settler-Master redeemed but the occupant of standing indicted: acknowledgment without absolution.

The decolonial objection, following Tuck and Yang, holds that acknowledgment names precisely the settler move to innocence that substitutes words for the return of land. The reply lies in the second clause of Axiom IV. Acknowledgment that does not reorganize standing is what the typology above calls integration, and hypogeal humanism rejects it. The rebranding of Shaman Vision Quest as Merlin's Forest is the film's own emblem of acknowledgment without reorganization, and it is offered as an indictment.

The posthumanist objection holds that any humanism remains anthropocentric. The reply is the fractal clause of Axiom II. Because the hypogeal repeats beneath the human, a humanism defined by debt cannot stop at the species line; the rabbits are creditors too.

The disability objection is the most concrete. During the film's promotion, Lupita Nyong'o described basing Red's voice on spasmodic dysphonia, a neurological voice disorder, and disability advocates, among them the National Spasmodic Dysphonia Association and RespectAbility, objected that the film tied a real condition to villainy. Nyong'o apologized, explaining that the voice was a composite of influences that included laryngeal fracture, vocal-cord hemorrhage, and her own experience of vocal injury. Rosemarie Garland-Thomson's *Extraordinary Bodies* (1997) analyzed how culture constructs the "normate" against bodies marked as deviant and spectacular. The objection is just with respect to the production discourse and to the film's first half, which codes the voice as monstrous for the sake of fear. The twist retroactively re-sounds the voice as an injury inflicted by the heroine, so that the disabled villain is revealed as the victim of the normate's violence; Nyong'o's own account of the voice as partly modeled on laryngeal trauma supports this reading. Hypogeal humanism reads Red's voice as testimony. It does not thereby absolve the film of trading on the first reading for its scares.

CODA

The Company of Wolves: Jason's Mask and the General Strike of the Mirror

For the first time since they were made, the doubles have stopped doubling.

11:11

The film ends twice. In the first ending, Adelaide, having killed Red beneath the boardwalk, finds Jason in hiding and carries him out. As the family drives away, memory returns, and the 1986 sequence replays from its true side: the underground girl strangling the surface girl, chaining her to a bed below, and climbing into the light in the *Thriller* shirt. In the back seat Jason studies his mother. She meets his look and smiles. He pulls his werewolf mask down over his face. In the second ending, helicopters reveal the Tethered standing hand in hand in an unbroken line across the hills and over the horizon. This coda reads the two endings in turn and then gathers the argument.

§ The boy and the mask

Jason's gesture admits four readings, and the film's achievement is to sustain all four.

It is *concealment*. The boy hides what he knows and enters the epistemology of ignorance that sustains the surface (Chapter Six); the next generation is inducted into the forgetting on which its standing depends.

It is *solidarity*. Like Carter's girl among the wolves (Chapter Three), he chooses his mother knowing what she is, and lies down in the company of wolves rather than flee them.

It is *survival*. It is Dunbar's mask (Chapter Two), the face that grins and lies so that its wearer may live in a world that would destroy him if it saw.

It is *apprenticeship*. Throughout the film Jason is an aspiring magician who practices his tricks on his family. In Christopher Nolan's *The Prestige* (2006), adapted from Christopher Priest's novel (1995), the greatest illusion depends on a body that drops beneath the stage and drowns in a tank each night while its copy reappears before an applauding house, and the magician confesses that he never knew whether he would be

the one in the tank or the one taking the bow. Jason now knows how the trick is done, and he has already performed a version of it. On the road, realizing that Pluto copies his movements, he walked backward until his double followed him into a burning car and died: the control the makers sought over the tether, discovered by a child and used to kill. The mask is the apprentice's decision about whether to perform it. He has become the doubting Thomas of Chapter Six, who has seen the wounds; what he will do with what he knows is withheld.

The film refuses to decide among these readings. Its last act of authorship is to hand the decision to the youngest member of the surface family and, through him, to the spectator, who has also just learned how the trick is done.

§ The chain

Chapter Five read the final image as an acephalic Leviathan, sovereignty without a sovereign. Two further readings complete it.

The first concerns time. For the whole of their existence the Tethered have mirrored the present: when the surface eats, they eat; when it dances, they dance. In 2019 no one above is holding hands. The chain repeats an event of 1986 that only the depth remembers. The Tethered, who could only reflect, now remember. The chain is the first act of history performed by the underground: not a reflection but a citation.

Marx opened the *Eighteenth Brumaire* with sentences the chain illuminates: "Die Menschen machen ihre eigene Geschichte, aber sie machen sie nicht aus freien Stücken"—men make their own history, but they do not make it as they please—and the tradition of the dead generations weighs like a nightmare on the brains of the living, so that revolutions conjure the spirits of the past and borrow their names, slogans, and costumes. The Tethered make their history in a borrowed costume and a borrowed choreography, as Marx's revolutionaries did. Marx also amended Hegel's remark that world-historical facts occur twice: the first time, he added, as tragedy, the second as farce. *Us* reverses the sequence. Hands Across America was the farce, solidarity as a fifteen-minute broadcast; the Untethering is the tragedy, the same image performed by the dispossessed over the bodies of the dead.

The second reading concerns violence. Walter Benjamin's "Zur Kritik der Gewalt" (1921), drawing on Georges Sorel's *Réflexions sur la violence* (1908), distinguished the political strike, which seeks concessions within the existing order, from the proletarian general strike, which seeks nothing within that order and aims only at its suspension: a pure means without instrumental end. The chain is a *general strike of the mirror*. Having killed, the Tethered now simply stand. They imitate no one. They demand nothing and propose nothing; the surface has no counterparty with whom to negotiate and no gesture to reflect back. For the first time since they were made, the doubles have stopped doubling.

Whether this stillness is the pure means Benjamin hoped for or the founding tableau of a new mythic order—whether it opens a different arrangement or merely announces the old one's crisis—the film declines to say. The refusal is principled. A cinema of the surface cannot show what lies beyond the arrangement that produced it; it can show the arrangement stopping.

§ Conclusion

This dissertation has argued that *Us* is a theory of the human. Its twist abolishes the original and leaves only position (Chapters One and Four). Its metaphysics inverts Du Bois, placing one soul in two bodies, and locates humanity in standing rather than essence (Chapter Two). Its feminism exposes the sororicidal foundation of liberal selfhood, the emancipation of one woman purchased by the burial of another (Chapter Three). Its economy is trickle-down mimesis, the descent of form without content, which binds even the revolt of the dispossessed to the spectacles of the advantaged (Chapters Four and Five). Its theology is substitution, the conversion of the trickster's escape into the priest's sacrifice under a covenant the surface forgot it had made (Chapter Six). Against the three responses the film depicts—exorcism, reversal, and integration—it gestures toward a fourth it does not depict: acknowledgment, the anamnestic solidarity of the one who stands with the one on whom she stands, made material in a reorganization of standing (Chapter Seven).

The name of that fourth response is hypogeal humanism. Its premise is botanical: a shoot rises because its cotyledons stay below and spend themselves in the dark. Its claim is political: no one stands in the light on her own ground. Its demand is ethical: the one who stands must learn on what, and on whom, she stands, and then stand differently.

The title's pronoun was always the argument. *Us* is the word for a collective that finds itself, at last, as the object of its own regard. The human, the film suggests, begins at the moment the one who stands looks down and recognizes, in the face beneath her, the debt she has been calling her life.

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INDEX TERMS

Keywords

Jordan Peele · Us (2019) · horror studies · Black horror · doppelgänger · the uncanny · return of the repressed · mirror stage · shadow archetype · synchronicity · monstrous double · mimetic desire · double consciousness · sartorial schema · respectability politics · Afropessimism · social death · ontological terror · trickster ontology · Signifyin(g) · feminist film theory · the madwoman in the attic · sororicidal foundation · Final Girl · monstrous-feminine · abjection · subaltern speech · flesh and body · coerced performance · performativity · colonial mimicry · simulacrum · overturning Platonism · trickle-down mimesis · society of the spectacle · old mole · accursed share · biopolitics · necropolitics · bare life · settler colonialism · hauntology · political theology · covenant theology · Akedah · sacrificial substitution · fugitive substitution · humanism · counter-humanism · posthumanism · matrixial theory · care ethics · disability studies · anamnestic solidarity · positional personhood · hypogeal humanism

11:11

The human is not the one who stands, but the one who knows on what, and on whom, she stands.

